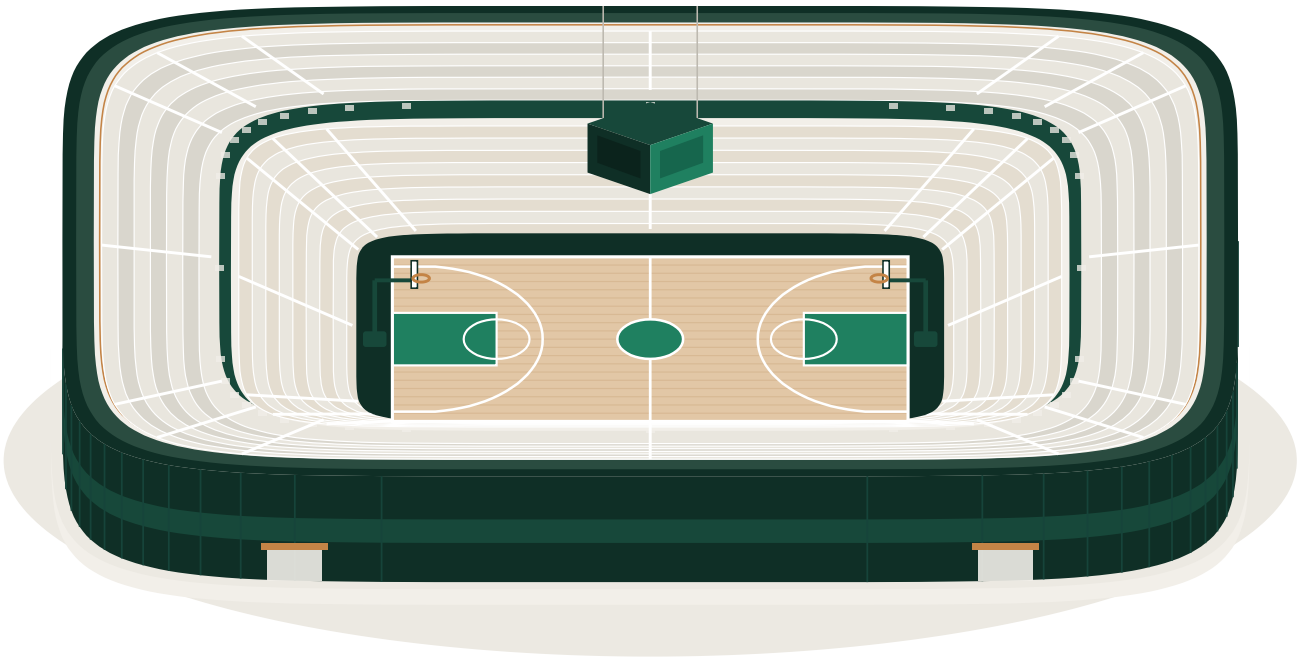
MARKET INTELLIGENCE BRIEFING / OCTOBER 2026

The WNBA in 2026: Crowds, Team Finances, and Expansion

Crowds, money, and rights in the Women's National Basketball Association (WNBA).

3.79M regular season attendance across 330 games in 2026, a league record, with 86% of the increase from two new teams



Prepared by Katherine Rowe
Playbook Strategies / playbookstrategies.co

Independent analysis. Not affiliated with or endorsed by the WNBA, the WNBPA, or any team.

WNBA / LAST UPDATED OCTOBER 27, 2026 / PREPARED BY KATHERINE ROWE

The WNBA in 2026: Crowds, Team Finances, and Expansion

Crowds, money, and rights in a league that grew from 13 teams to 15.

1 Executive summary

The commercial picture

The WNBA drew 3.79 million fans to its 330 regular season games in 2026, 20.5% more than in 2025. Most of that increase came with two new teams: Portland and Toronto supplied 86% of the added attendance, while the average crowd across the league rose 4.4%. This briefing analyzes how much of that demand each team keeps as revenue, what fans pay per game as the home schedule grows from 22 to 25 games in 2027, and which rights a partner can buy from the league, a team, a broadcaster, or a venue.

2026 REGULAR SEASON ATTENDANCE	AVERAGE CROWD GROWTH	2025 TEAM REVENUE RANGE
3.79M	**+4.4%**	**$16M–$78M**
330 games; 20.5% above 2025	11,474 against 10,986; the league release says 21%	Forbes estimates for 13 teams; median $28M

1. **Expansion added most of the new attendance.** Portland and Toronto drew 556,535 between them, while the other 13 teams, which played the same 22 home games in both seasons, added 87,929, or 2.8%. Within that small net gain the teams moved in different directions: Atlanta and Minnesota raised their average crowds by 55% and 24%, while Washington and Chicago fell by 16% and 9%. In Atlanta and Toronto, a handful of dates in larger arenas supplied 62% and 48% of the season's visits. Online, Indiana's accounts produced about three in every five team social impressions, and Atlanta's engagements and social value grew fastest after it traded for Angel Reese. Sections 3–5
2. **Team revenue varies more than crowds.** Forbes puts 2025 revenue between $16M in Atlanta and $78M at Golden State, with Golden State, Indiana, and New York earning 42% of the 13 team total. Renewal invoices for 2027 have risen faster than prices per game because the home schedule is growing from 22 to 25 games, so a renewal invoice can rise 13.6% and be fair. Teams inside NBA ownership groups had a median 2025 revenue estimate of $35.5M against $28M for independent teams, a gap that also reflects differences in market size and arena access. Sections 6–8, 14–18
3. **Costs and media rights changed in the same year.** The 2026 salary cap rose from $1.5M to $7.0M under a seven year CBA, while national media contracts with a reported value of $2.2B to $3.1B began a run through 2036. Cleveland, Detroit, and Philadelphia will pay a reported $250M each to join as expansion teams between 2028 and 2030, five times the $50M Golden State paid for its 2025 entry. Sections 9–13, 19

How to read this briefing: crowds come from the 2026 regular season, team finances from Forbes estimates of the 2025 season, and prices from dated observations between 2025 and 2027, so the periods differ from one section to the next. Each figure carries a tag for the kind of evidence behind it. All money is in US dollars unless marked C$.

Background: why the WNBA

The WNBA is the longest running women's professional team sports league in the United States. The NBA founded it, with the league playing its first season in 1997 with eight teams. In 2026 it played its 30th season with 15 teams, and upcoming expansions take it to 18 by 2030.

1997
First season, with eight teams owned and run by the NBA

15
Teams in 2026, the most since 2002 and the first in Canada

18
Teams by 2030, after Cleveland, Detroit, and Philadelphia join

From eight teams to fifteen

The NBA Board of Governors approved the league in April 1996, and the first game tipped off in June 1997. The league grew to 16 teams by 2000, then shrank over the next decade as clubs folded, playing with 12 teams from 2010 through 2024. Golden State joined in 2025, the first expansion team since Atlanta in 2008. Portland and Toronto joined in 2026, and Toronto became the first WNBA team based outside the United States.

Why the league is worth close study

- **Growth from new teams.** Total attendance grew 20.5% in 2026, with Portland and Toronto supplying 86% of the increase. The 13 returning teams grew 2.8% while playing the same 22 home games each, which gives a cleaner read on demand at established teams than the league total does.
- **Larger media contracts.** The national media contracts that began in 2026 have a reported core value of $2.2B over 11 years, about six times the previous ESPN agreement according to Forbes, and later agreements with CBS, ION, and Versant took the total to $3.1B. The league has not published how that money is divided between teams, players, and the league office.
- **Higher player costs.** The CBA agreed in March 2026 raised the salary cap from $1.5M to $7.0M and expanded and restructured the revenue sharing that began under the 2020 agreement, tying the cap to league and team revenue. Teams now carry a much larger fixed cost, though without published accounts the effect on any team's profit cannot be measured from the outside.

2 Market snapshot and scope

Figures cover the 2026 regular season and 2025 financial estimates unless noted.

REGULAR SEASON ATTENDANCE

3.79M

3,786,546 across 330 games; 212 sellouts, per the league

TEAM REVENUE, 2025

$430M

13 teams, Forbes estimates; playoffs excluded

TEAM VALUES, 2026

$5.39B

13 teams, Forbes; up 41% for the 12 teams valued in both years

NATIONAL MEDIA RIGHTS

$2.2B

Core package, 2026 to 2036; $3.1B with later deals

SALARY CAP, 2026

$7.0M

Up from $1.5M in 2025 under the new CBA

LEAGUE SPONSORS

46

Official sponsors at opening week, per SBJ; 45 in 2025

Scope and dates

The attendance analysis covers all 330 regular season games in 2026 and the 286 games of 2025, with game records back to 2024, and excludes the playoffs, the All-Star Game, and the Commissioner's Cup final. Team finances use Forbes estimates of 2025 revenue and 2026 values for the 13 teams that played in 2025, which leaves out Portland and Toronto. Ticket prices come from 150 dated observations for six teams and 66 renewal records contributed by fans of two teams, and none of them is weighted by seats sold. The league partner map covers 33 brand rows, short of the 46 sponsors Sports Business Journal counted. The 2026 Finals between Golden State and Atlanta stood at 2–2 on October 25.

How to read the evidence

Reported / calculated: published figures, or arithmetic on them. **Estimate / modeled:** publisher estimates and illustrative scenarios. **Sample:** prices and invoices captured from team pages or contributed by fans, not weighted by seats. **Public page count:** what the research found on public pages; contracts may hold more. All money is in US dollars unless marked C$.

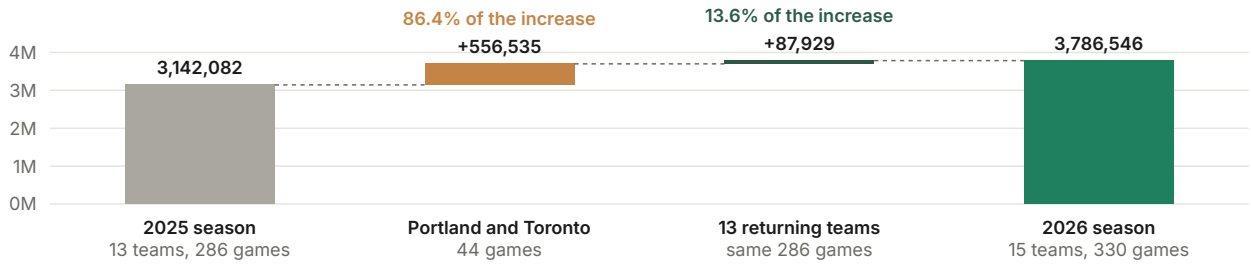
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3 Attendance and expansion

The WNBA reported 3.8 million regular season attendance in 2026, a league record. Adding up the 15 team totals gives 3,786,546 across 330 games, up 644,464, or 20.5%, on 2025. Attendance here means tickets distributed for each game, as the teams report it, so a season ticket holder who goes to all 22 home games counts 22 times, and the total does not, on its own, show how many different people bought tickets.

Figure 1. Where the 2026 attendance increase came from REPORTED / CALCULATED



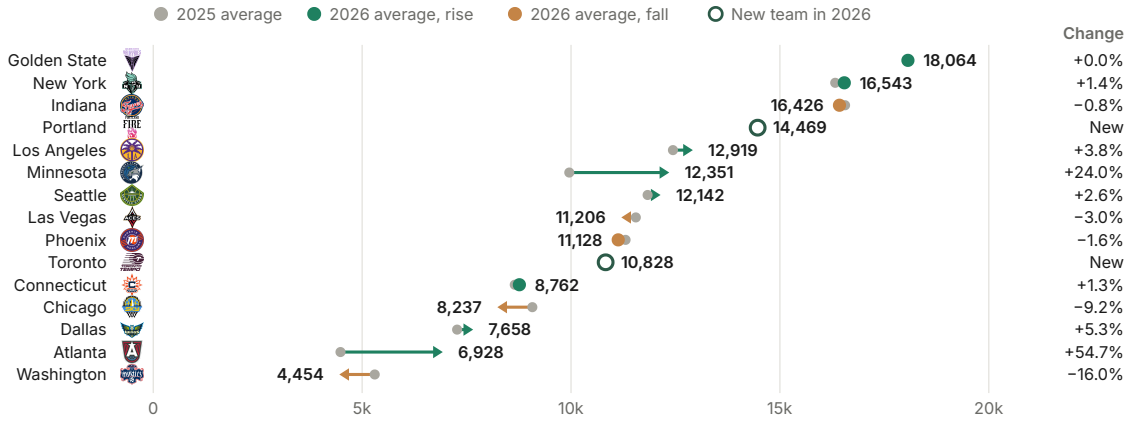
Portland and Toronto account for 86.4% of the added attendance. The 13 teams that played both seasons added 87,929 visits, 2.8% more than their 2025 total, on the same 22 home games each, which is the closest measure in this data of demand growth at established teams.

Source: Across the Timeline, 2026 game records reconciled to all 15 team totals; 2025 league total of 3,142,082 from the 2025 season summary.

3.1 Average crowd: 21% or 4.4%

The league's October 14 release says average attendance rose 21% in 2026, to 11,474 a game. The 2026 average matches the team totals, but the comparison with 2025 does not: the league drew 3,142,082 fans across 286 games in 2025, an average of 10,986, and 11,474 is 4.4% above that. Total attendance rose 20.5%, which is close enough to the league's 21% to suggest the release applied the growth in total attendance to the average. This briefing uses 4.4%.

Figure 2. Average home crowd by team, 2026 against 2025 REPORTED / CALCULATED



Atlanta's average rose 55% because it played six home games at State Farm Arena in 2026, where they averaged 15,827, against two games in larger arenas in 2025, and its Gateway Center average also rose, from 3,281 to 3,592. Washington's fell 16% while all 21 of its CareFirst Arena games drew 4,200, the arena's capacity, because it played one game in a larger arena in 2026 against four in 2025.

Source: Across the Timeline, 2026 game records; 2025 team averages, rounded, from the supplied team season dataset.

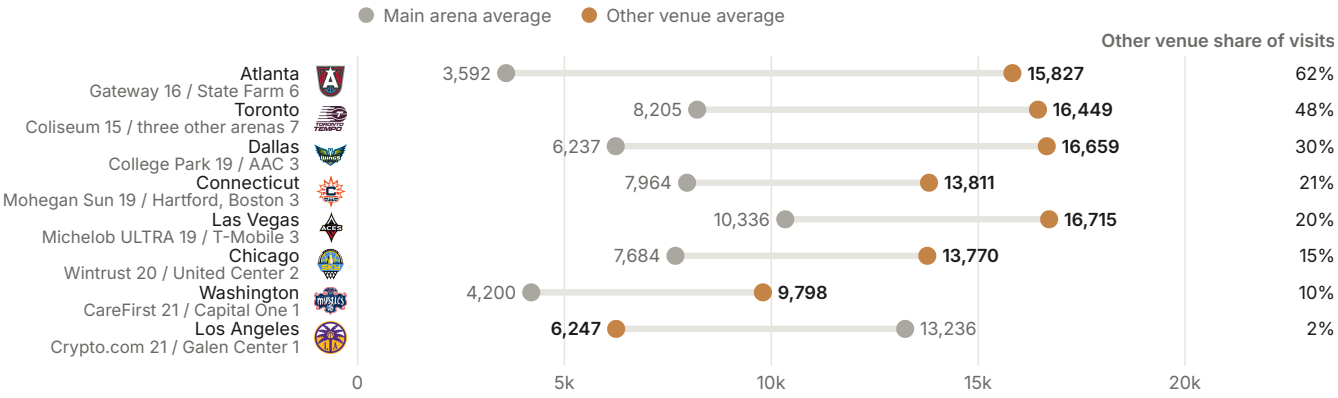
3.2 Sellouts

The league counted 212 sellouts in 2026, 64% of regular season games and 33 more than in 2025, and four teams sold out every home game. A sellout means a team distributed every seat in the arena that aligns with capacity.

4 Venues and crowd distribution

Eight of the 15 teams played at least one home game away from their main arena in 2026, and in all but one case those games drew larger crowds than the team's usual arena. A season average that includes those dates says more about a team's biggest nights than about demand at the arena it uses most.

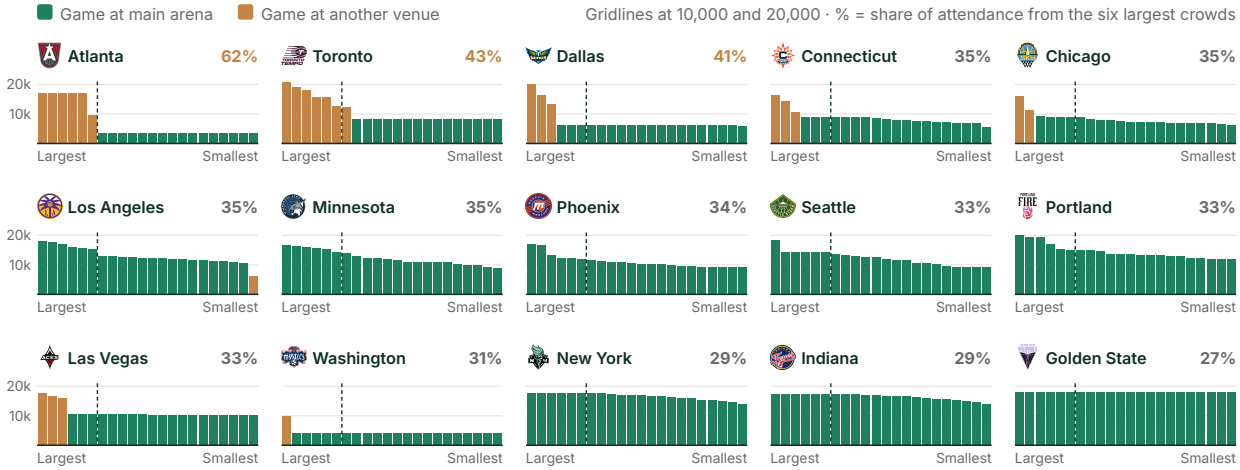
Figure 3. Main arena average against other venue average, 2026 REPORTED / CALCULATED



Atlanta drew 3,592 a game at the Gateway Center and 15,827 at State Farm Arena. Toronto's seven games at Scotiabank Arena, the Bell Centre in Montreal, and Rogers Arena in Vancouver averaged 16,449, about twice its 8,205 at the Coca-Cola Coliseum. Los Angeles was the exception, with its one game at USC's Galen Center drawing 6,247 against 13,236 at Crypto.com Arena.

Source: Across the Timeline, 2026 game records, venue as listed in the game feed.

Figure 4. Every 2026 home crowd, sorted from largest to smallest REPORTED



Each bar is one home game, and the dashed line marks the six largest crowds. Atlanta's six games at State Farm Arena supplied 62% of its season attendance, while Toronto's largest six supplied 43% and Dallas's 41%. Golden State drew 18,064 at all 22 games, so its six largest supplied 27%, the share when every crowd is the same size.

Source: Across the Timeline, 2026 game records, venue as listed in the game feed. Six largest crowds are the top quarter of 22 dates, rounded up.

4.1 What a larger arena changes

A larger arena gives a team more seats to sell, while the revenue it keeps depends on the prices it can hold and on its share of ticket, food, parking, and premium income under the lease. None of the 15 teams discloses its lease. Atlanta moves all of its home games to State Farm Arena in 2027 and Dallas moves to the American Airlines Center, and their 2027 results will be the first evidence of what a larger arena adds for those franchises.

5 Team audiences and home markets

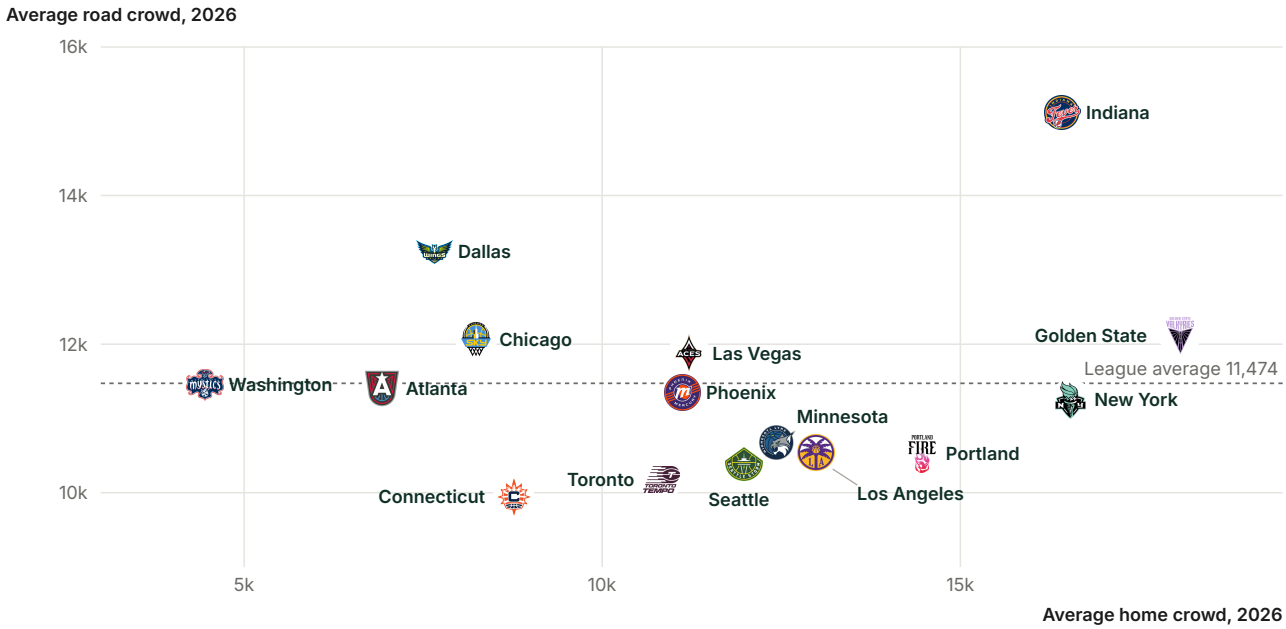
The 15 teams of 2026 play in 14 US markets and Toronto. Connecticut moves to Houston in 2027. The next additions are Cleveland in 2028, Detroit in 2029, and Philadelphia in 2030. The owner, or ownership group, of the local NBA team owns each of those four teams.

Figure 5. 2026 teams and announced entries REPORTED



Source: WNBA team and expansion announcements; NBA.com, Connecticut Sun sale approval, May 2026.

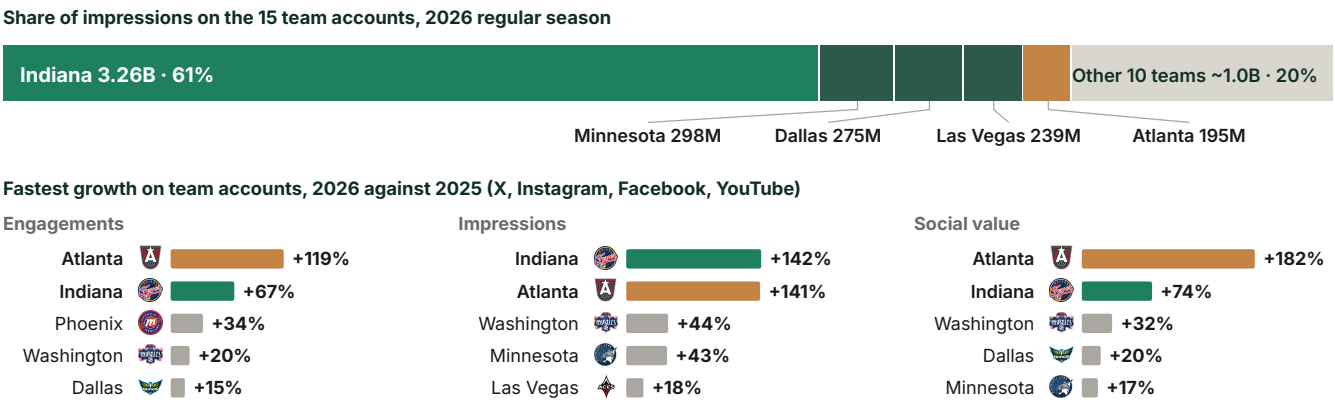
Figure 6. Average home crowd against average road crowd, 2026 CALCULATED



Indiana drew an average of 15,117 as the visiting team, 32% above the league average and about 1,900 more than Dallas, the next highest. Golden State has the largest home crowds and drew 12,116 on the road, 6% above the league average. Road crowds also depend on which arenas a team visits, so the comparison shows where crowds were largest and does not, on its own, isolate the effect of one team or player.

Source: Across the Timeline, 2026 game records.

Figure 7. Team social accounts: share of impressions and fastest growth, 2026 ESTIMATE



Zoomph counted 3.26 billion impressions on Indiana's accounts during the 2026 regular season and put their social value at $106M, nine times that of Dallas, the second team at $11.6M. Zoomph also reports that Indiana's accounts produced more social value and impressions than any NBA team's in the 2025/26 NBA season. Its statement that Indiana had 9.2 times the average team's impressions implies about 5.3 billion across the 15 teams, so roughly three in every five team impressions came from Indiana. An impression counts each time a post is shown, and social value is Zoomph's estimate of what the same exposure would cost as paid media, so neither figure is a count of fans or revenue that reaches the team.

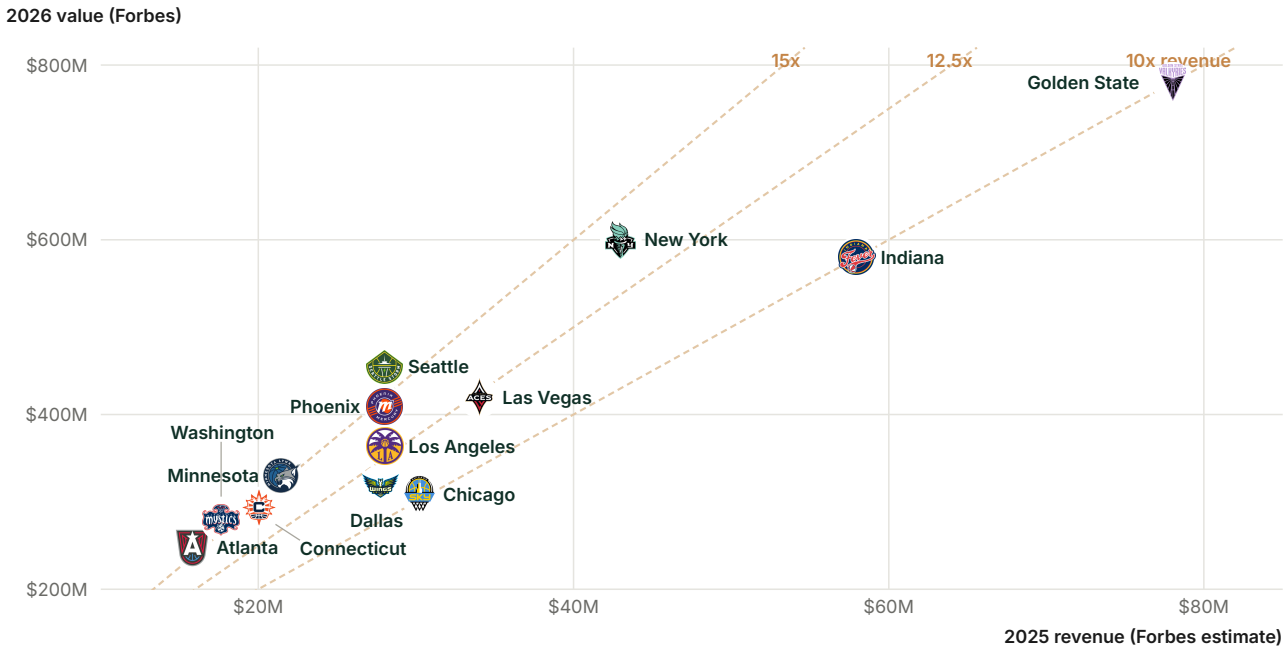
Source: Zoomph, 2026 WNBA Regular Season Report, team and league accounts on X, Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, and TikTok, May 8 to September 24, 2026, numbers as of October 1, 2026. Zoomph measures unauthenticated accounts, and its figures may differ from the teams' own analytics. The total for the other ten teams and the shares are Playbook Strategies calculations from Zoomph's statement that Indiana had 9.2 times the average team's impressions. Growth compares team accounts on X, Instagram, Facebook, and YouTube in the 2026 and 2025 regular seasons and leaves out TikTok.

Atlanta's engagements and social value grew fastest of any team, by 119% and 182% against 2025, and its impressions rose 141%, second only to Indiana's 142%, after the team acquired Angel Reese in a trade in April 2026. Reese has more than 12.7 million followers across platforms, the most of any WNBA player, and Atlanta also had the largest rise in average home crowd of any returning team, 55%, mostly from its six State Farm Arena dates. Washington ranked third for growth in impressions (44%) and social value (32%) while it played 21 of 22 home games in a 4,200 seat arena, so its online audience grew in a season its crowds fell 16%.

6 Team revenue and valuations

Forbes estimates that the 13 teams that played in 2025 earned $430M that season, excluding playoffs, and values them at $5.39B in 2026, 12.5 times revenue. These are publisher estimates built from transactions and interviews. Section 6.2 sets out Sportico's separate series.

Figure 8. 2025 revenue against 2026 value ESTIMATE



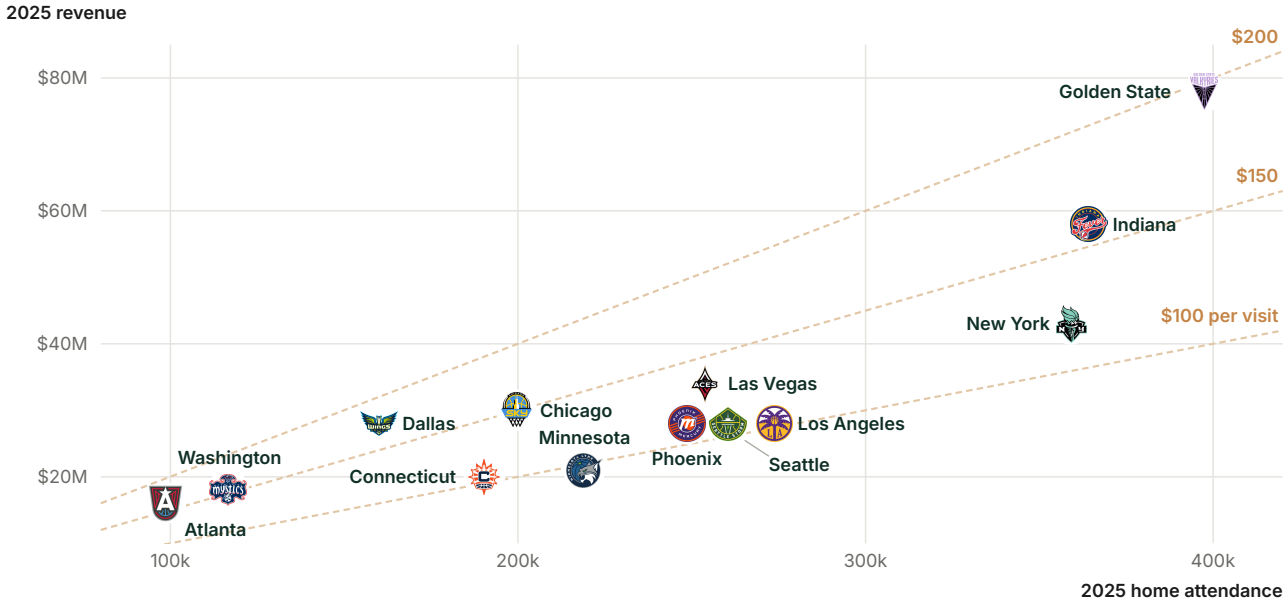
Dashed lines mark 10, 12.5, and 15 times revenue. Golden State, Indiana, and New York earned $179M between them, 42% of the total, while the median team earned $28M. Values vary less than revenue: Atlanta earned a fifth of Golden State's revenue, and Forbes values it at about a third of Golden State's value. All six teams valued at 15 times revenue or more had 2025 revenue of $28M or less, which suggests buyers are paying for expected growth at the smaller teams.

Source: Forbes, The WNBA's Most Valuable Teams 2026, May 7, 2026. Revenue excludes playoffs; values include arena economics but not arena real estate.

6.1 Growth at the same 12 teams

For the 12 teams Forbes covered in both studies, estimated revenue rose 56%, from $226M in 2024 to $352M in 2025, while values rose 41%, from $3.26B to $4.61B, between the 2025 and 2026 studies. Sportico reported in October that Golden State's 2026 revenue passed $100M, a first for a women's team, and CNBC valued the team at $1B earlier in the year. Those are 2026 figures, and Figure 8 keeps Golden State's 2025 estimate of $78M so the comparison uses the same season for every team.

Figure 9. 2025 home attendance against 2025 revenue CALCULATED



Dashed lines mark revenue of $100, $150, and $200 per home visit. Revenue per home visit runs from $96 at Minnesota to $196 at Golden State, and it includes media distributions and sponsorship as well as ticket sales, so it is not a ticket price. Every team receives league distributions whatever its crowd size, which helps place Atlanta ($162) and Washington ($154), the teams with the two smallest crowds, third and fifth.

Source: Forbes 2025 revenue estimates divided by 2025 home attendance from game records.

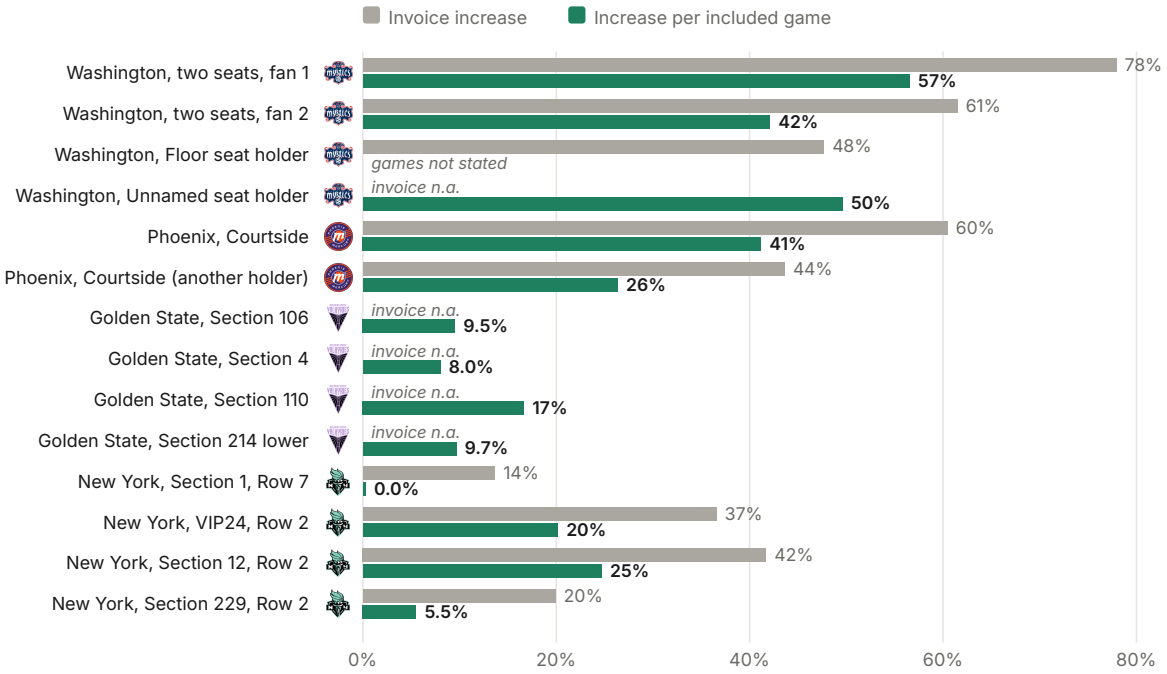
6.2 Two valuation series and one sale

Sportico values the same 13 teams at $5.56B, $170M more than Forbes, with the largest gaps at Golden State ($70M higher at Sportico), Los Angeles ($50M higher), and Minnesota ($35M higher). Indiana has the largest gap in the other direction, $20M lower at Sportico. Tilman Fertitta paid $300M for the Connecticut Sun in the only priced sale of 2026, according to NBA.com, the same figure as the Forbes value published a week before the league approved the sale and the move to Houston.

7 Ticket pricing and renewals

Teams sent 2027 renewal invoices during the 2026 season, while the home schedule grows from 22 to 25 games in 2027. An invoice can therefore rise 13.6% with no change in the price of each game, so every comparison in this section divides each invoice by the games it includes.

Figure 10. Same seat renewals, 2026 to 2027 SAMPLE



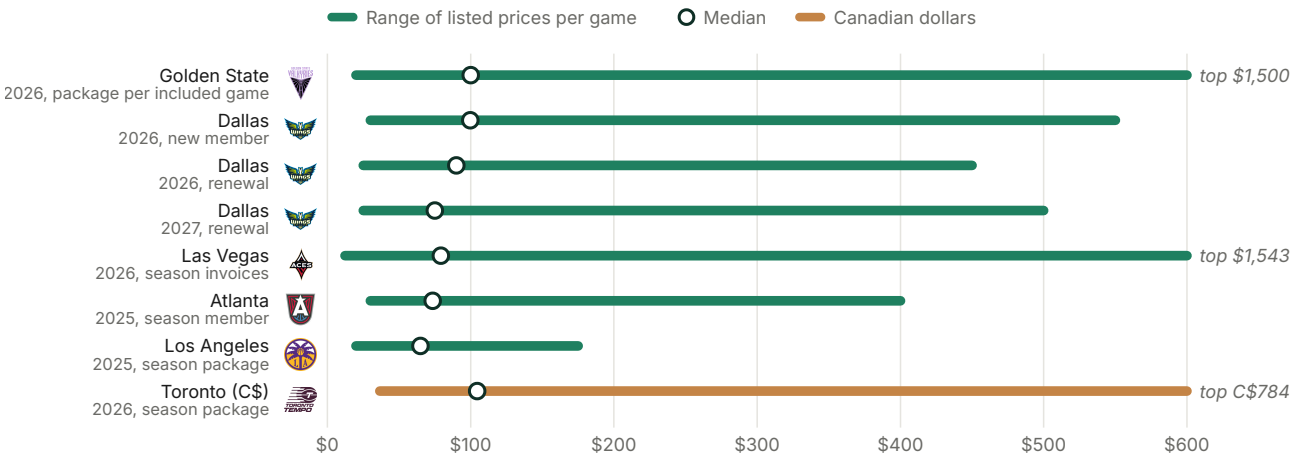
Washington's examples show the steepest increases, 42% to 57% per game. New York's Section 1, Row 7 shows the effect of the schedule alone: the invoice rises 13.6% and the price stays at $95 a game. Las Vegas reported a blended increase of 17.65% across its inventory and said 72% of its season tickets cost under $35 a game.

Source: Front Office Sports, invoices viewed for Washington and Phoenix; fan posted invoices for Washington and Golden State; community renewal sheet for New York. Selected examples, not team averages.

7.1 The community sample

Fans of New York and Golden State contributed 66 renewal records for 2026 to 2027, which show a median invoice increase of 13.7% and no change in the median price per game. Thirty three of New York's 40 records show no change per game. Golden State's 26 records rise between 5.5% and 11.1% per game, with a median of 8.4%, and its invoices rise further because the package grows from 23 to 26 included games. The records come from fans who chose to share them, so they show what renewals look like and do not, on their own, establish a team average.

Figure 11. Listed season ticket prices per included game SAMPLE



Median prices in these samples run from $65 a game at Los Angeles in 2025 to $100 at Golden State in 2026, and courtside seats reach $1,500 a game at Golden State and $1,543 at Las Vegas. The rows mix seasons, seat locations, renewal prices, and new member prices, so they show the list prices buyers see, which can differ from what teams earn per seat after discounts and unsold inventory.

Source: Team price maps and pricing graphics supplied for this research (150 observations); Las Vegas season invoices. Las Vegas 2027 public prices omitted for lack of a game count.

7.2 What $10 more is worth

Raising the price of 8,000 paid seats by $10 a game across a 25 game home season adds $2.0M in gross receipts, provided no buyers drop out. How much of that a team keeps depends on its lease and on any added cost, and no team discloses either.

REPRICED PAID SEATS
8,000
Illustration; not a team's actual paid count

INCREASE PER SEAT PER GAME
$10
No loss of demand assumed

GROSS RECEIPTS ADDED
$2.0M
25 home games; before lease split and costs

8 Venue terms and facilities

Most WNBA teams rent their arena. A company in the team's own ownership group runs the arena for four teams: Golden State, New York, Indiana, and Phoenix. The other 11 rent from a city, a public authority, a casino or tribal operator, or an arena company, and none of their lease terms is public.

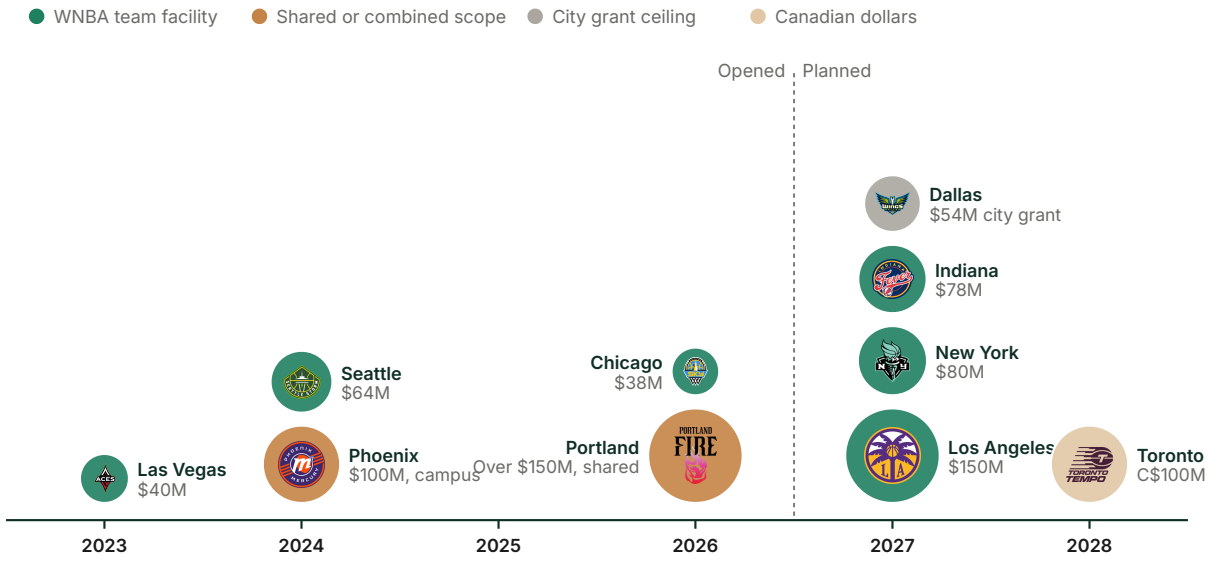
WHO RUNS EACH TEAM'S ARENA, 2026

TEAM	2026 MAIN VENUE	OPERATOR	RELATIONSHIP
Atlanta	Gateway Center / State Farm	Public operator	Two venue agreements
Chicago	Wintrust Arena	Oak View Group	Tenant
Connecticut	Mohegan Sun Arena	Mohegan arena operator	Tenant until 2027 move
Dallas	College Park Center / AAC	Center Operating Company (AAC)	Two venues; AAC tenant in 2027
Golden State	Chase Center	Warriors / Chase Center	Same ownership group
Indiana	Gainbridge Fieldhouse	Fieldhouse Management / Pacers Sports & Entertainment	Same operating group
Las Vegas	Michelob ULTRA Arena	MGM Resorts International	Tenant

TEAM	2026 MAIN VENUE	OPERATOR	RELATIONSHIP
Los Angeles	Crypto.com Arena	AEG	Tenant
Minnesota	Target Center	Legends Global	Tenant; owner shared with Timberwolves
New York	Barclays Center	BSE Global	Same ownership group
Phoenix	Mortgage Matchup Center	Suns / Mercury operating group	Same operating group
Portland	Moda Center	Rip City Management	Tenant
Seattle	Climate Pledge Arena	Oak View Group	Tenant
Toronto	Coca-Cola Coliseum	MLSE	Tenant
Washington	CareFirst Arena	Events DC	Tenant

Source: venue and team announcements; WNBA, Connecticut Sun sale approval, May 13, 2026; City of Portland, Moda Center; Events DC, CareFirst Arena. Ticket, food, parking, premium, and signage retention is not disclosed for any team.

Figure 12. Announced practice facility and campus investments REPORTED



Ten teams have announced or opened a training facility with a disclosed budget, and four of them open in 2027: Indiana, Los Angeles, New York, and Dallas. The amounts are not like for like, because Phoenix's $100M covers a Suns and Mercury employee campus, Portland's covers a campus shared with the Thorns, and Dallas's $54M is the city's grant limit, with team money on top. The CBA now sets facility and staffing standards, so each of these buildings also adds a running cost that the team carries every year.

Source: Team and city announcements, 2023 to 2026; Dallas City Council resolution; Toronto City Council, July 2026. Amounts are capital budgets at announcement and differ in scope and currency, so they do not sum.

9 League rights and partners

The league, each team, the broadcasters, the venues, and the players each sell different rights. A brand that signs with the league gets league marks and national events, and it needs separate deals for team uniforms, arena signage, or player endorsements.

WHO SELLS WHAT IN THE WNBA

SELLER	WHAT IT SELLS	EXAMPLES IN THE 2026 EVIDENCE
League	League marks, national partnerships, Draft, All-Star, and WNBA Live events, central media	Nike, Google, Deloitte; State Street (Draft); State Farm, Kia (All-Star events)
Team	Team marks, local inventory, jersey patches, within league rules	Albert, Kaiser Permanente, CIBC
Broadcaster	Ad spots, studio, and broadcast integrations, under separate agreements	Not captured in this research
Venue	Naming rights, concessions, suites, parking, and signage, as leases allow	Chase Center, Barclays Center, Mortgage Matchup Center
Players / WNBPA	Individual endorsements and group player licensing	Separate from league sponsorship

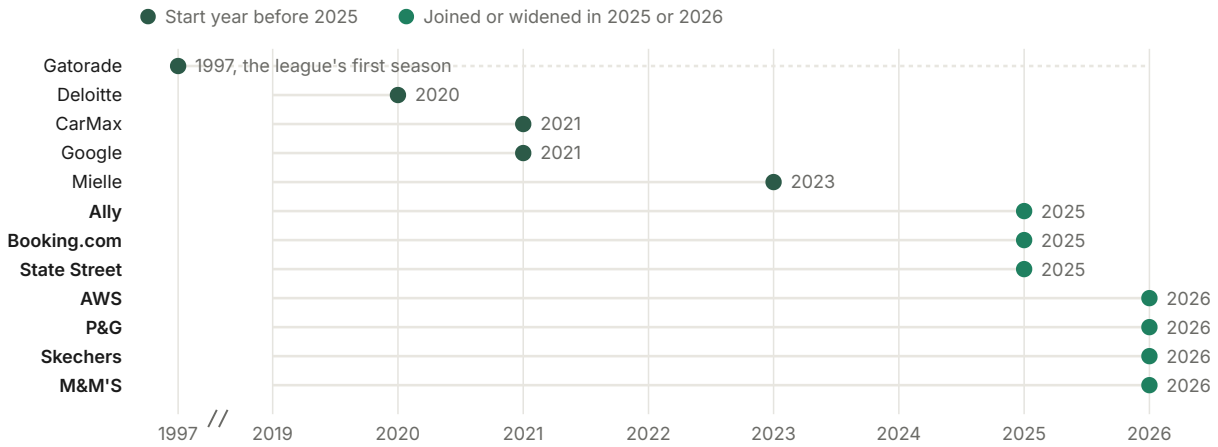
Figure 13. League partners captured, by relationship PUBLIC PAGE COUNT

RELATIONSHIP	BRANDS	BRANDS CAPTURED
Changemaker	7	Ally, AT&T, AWS, CarMax, Deloitte, Google, Nike
Official partner	8	P&G, Mielle, State Street SPY, Skechers, M&M'S, Booking.com, Wilson, Gatorade
P&G portfolio brand	6	Secret, Olay, Tampax, Downy, Tide, Gillette Venus (one agreement with P&G)
Event partner, 2026	12	American Express, Bumble, Capella University, Coach, DoorDash, DICK'S Sporting Goods, Kia, La Crema, Panini, State Farm, Tissot, Xfinity

Sports Business Journal counted 46 official sponsors at the start of the 2026 season, up from a record 45 in 2025. This research verifies 33 brand rows, including six P&G brands under one agreement, which makes 27 agreements. The table lists event partners from their appearances at 2026 events, and an appearance does not, on its own, confirm a full league contract.

Source: WNBA Changemakers page; WNBA and NBA announcements, 2020 to 2026; NBA, 2026 WNBA Live details; Sports Business Journal, May 13, 2026.

Figure 14. Start years of league partners with a published start PUBLIC PAGE COUNT



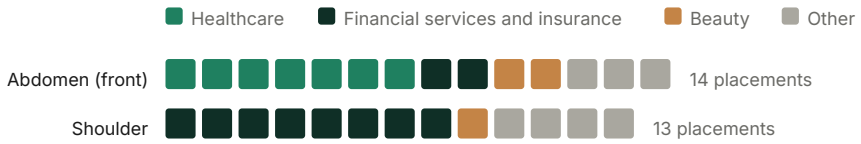
Gatorade has backed the league since its first season in 1997. Seven brands joined or widened their deals in 2025 or 2026: Ally, Booking.com, State Street, AWS, P&G, Skechers, and M&M'S. The announcements describe these deals as multiyear without giving an end year or a fee, so the timing of the league's next renewal cycle is not public.

Source: WNBA and partner announcements; SBJ, May 2026, for Gatorade.

10 Team partnerships and jersey inventory

Every team can sell a front of jersey patch and a shoulder patch. The May 2026 census found 27 placements across the 15 teams, 14 on the front and 13 on the shoulder. Atlanta listed no front partner, and Connecticut and Minnesota no shoulder partner, at the time of the census.

Figure 15. 2026 jersey placements by sector PUBLIC PAGE COUNT



Healthcare holds 7 of the 14 front placements: hospital systems in Chicago, Connecticut, Golden State, Los Angeles, Minnesota, and Seattle, plus CVS in Dallas. Financial services and insurance hold 8 of the 13 shoulder placements, and the money app Albert holds three of them, in Atlanta, Dallas, and Los Angeles. Beauty brands hold three placements, two of them with the 2026 expansion teams.

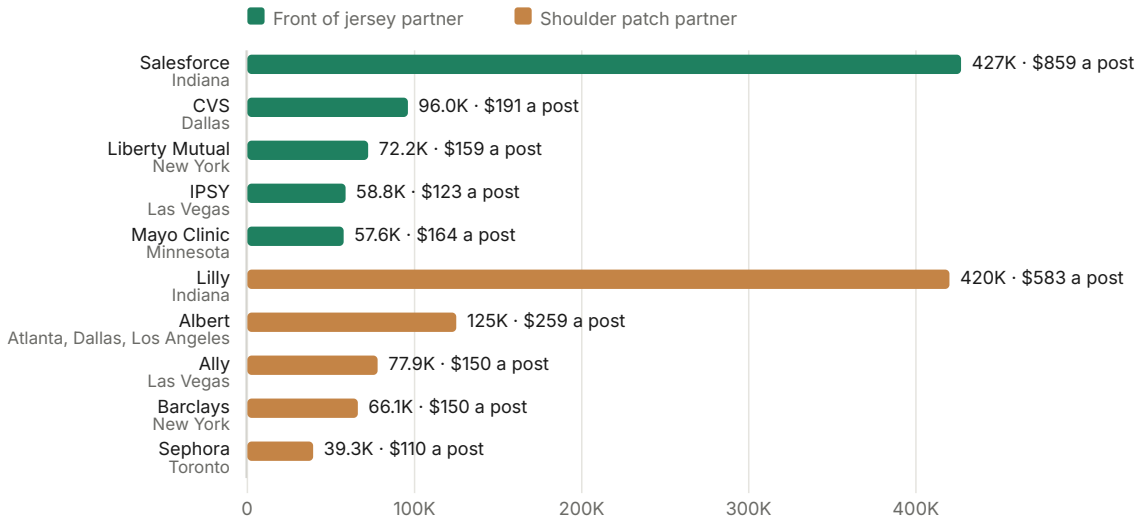
Source: Blinkfire Analytics, 2026 WNBA jersey sponsorships, May 20, 2026; team announcements.

2026 JERSEY PARTNERS BY TEAM

TEAM	FRONT OF JERSEY	SHOULDER
Atlanta	*None listed*	Albert
Chicago	UChicago Medicine	Magellan Corporation
Connecticut	Yale New Haven Health	*None listed*
Dallas	CVS	Albert
Golden State	Kaiser Permanente	Chase Freedom
Indiana	Salesforce	Lilly
Las Vegas	IPSY	Ally
Los Angeles	UCLA Health	Albert
Minnesota	Mayo Clinic	*None listed*
New York	Liberty Mutual	Barclays
Phoenix	Fry's Food Stores	Hero Bread
Portland	Lashify	Chime
Seattle	Providence Swedish	Symetra
Toronto	CIBC	Sephora
Washington	Vanda Pharmaceuticals	CarMax

10.1 What jersey and court assets deliver

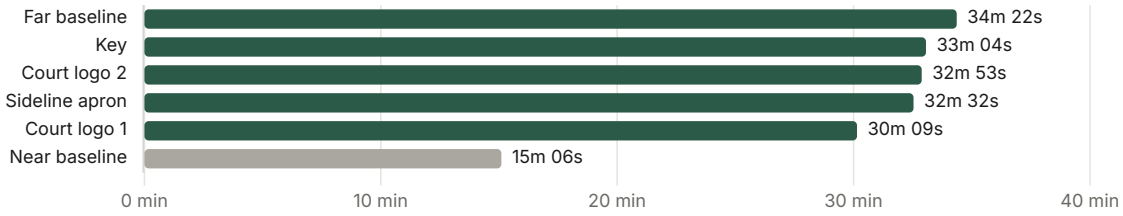
Figure 16. Logo impressions per social post, top five partners on each jersey asset THIRD PARTY MEASURE



Indiana's two partners averaged more than three times the logo exposure per post of any other partner in either list: Salesforce 427,000 impressions a post on the front of the jersey and Lilly 420,000 on the shoulder. Indiana's own posts produced about 93% of Salesforce's logo exposure, while team posts produced 50% for the average front of jersey partner and league and opponent accounts the rest, so most of what Salesforce receives depends on how often Indiana posts. Albert, the only brand on three teams' jerseys, averaged 125,000 per post with its patch, the highest outside Indiana. Front of jersey logos appeared in 44% more posts than patch logos, and video produced 71% of their impressions but 11% of their brand value.

Source: Zoomph, 2026 WNBA Regular Season Report: logo detection in league and team posts on X, Instagram, Facebook, and TikTok, May 8 to September 24, 2026. Brand value per post is Zoomph's paid media equivalent. Zoomph ranks the partners by brand value, and the chart orders them by impressions.

Figure 17. Average time on screen per court asset in a five game broadcast sample, 2026 THIRD PARTY MEASURE



The far baseline and the key were each on screen for about 33 to 34 minutes a game, because cameras follow play at either end of the court. The near baseline averaged 15 minutes, about half the time of court logo 1 and less than half of every other asset, because camera angles and fans block it. The sample covers five home teams and five networks, so it gives a rough ranking of assets and does not, on its own, value any one team's inventory.

Source: Zoomph broadcast analysis: Chicago at New York (WNYW), New York at Indiana (CBS), Indiana at Toronto (ION), Los Angeles at Dallas (ABC), Las Vegas at Portland (KPDX). Court logos 1 and 2 are the paired positions either side of half court.

Zoomph counts 24 beauty, wellness, and personal care brands sponsoring the league or its teams in 2026, ten of them new this season. Makeup and skincare is the largest group with seven brands, among them Olay, IPSY, Sephora, and Lashify, and period care brands hold six partnerships through Honey Pot, LOLA, Tampax, and Sequel.

Source: Zoomph, 2026 WNBA Regular Season Report, sponsorship category study; Blinkfire Analytics, May 20, 2026.

11 Media rights and audiences

The national contracts that began in 2026 run for 11 seasons, through 2036. Forbes reports the original Disney, Amazon, and NBCUniversal package at $2.2B, about $200M a year and six times the previous ESPN deal, and later agreements with CBS, ION, and Versant took the total to $3.1B. The league has not said how much it receives in 2026 or how much it passes to teams.

NATIONAL MEDIA PARTNERS AND 2026 LISTED INVENTORY

PARTNER	PLATFORM	SEASONS	2026 LISTED	RIGHTS NOTED
Disney	ABC / ESPN	2026–2036	30	Games and events; Finals rotation
NBCUniversal	NBC	2026–2036	7	Seven Sunday games
NBCUniversal	Peacock / NBCSN	2026–2036	15	Includes simulcasts; Finals simulcast
Amazon	Prime Video	2026–2036	30	Commissioner's Cup final additional
Paramount	CBS / Paramount+	2026	20	Long term renewal
Scripps (ION)	ION	2026	50	Friday night slate
Versant (USA)	USA Network	2026–2036	48	At least 50 a year with playoffs
NBA TV	NBA TV	2026	15	Continuing carriage
WNBA	League Pass	2026	Subscription	Selected live games and replays

Source: NBA, WNBA media agreements with Disney, Amazon, and NBCUniversal; WNBA, 2026 broadcast schedule; WNBA, Versant agreement, September 30, 2025; WNBA, CBS Sports agreement; Forbes, May 7, 2026.

The listed slots add up to 215, close to the 216 national games Forbes counts for 2026, though some games appear twice: Disney's 30 include events and Peacock simulcasts NBC games. Versant took over the USA Network games from the original NBCUniversal package after the cable networks separated, and its agreement guarantees at least 50 games a year, including playoffs.

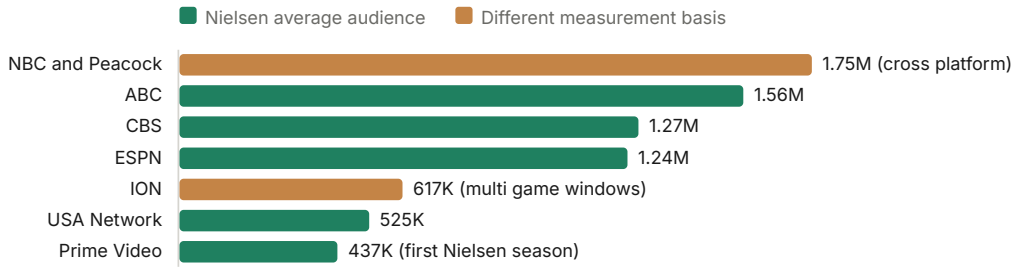
Figure 18. Audience measures: units, period, and interpretation DIFFERENT UNITS

MEASURE	PERIOD	REPORTED SIZE	UNIT	INTERPRETATION
National unique viewers	2026 regular season	More than 90M	Viewers	Reach across national networks; not an average audience
Hours watched	2026 regular season	More than 320M	Hours	Coverage hours, distinct from viewers
Telecasts at 1M or more	2026 regular season	51	Telecasts	Up from 19 in 2025; nine passed 2M, up from four
League social views	2026 regular season	4B	Views	Up 28%; counts each view
League and team social impressions	2026 regular season	8.19B	Impressions	Zoomph; up 75% on 2025, growth excludes TikTok
League and team social value	2026 regular season	$259M	Paid media equivalent	Zoomph estimate; up 55%; not revenue
League social following	October 2026	More than 11.4M	Followers	Platforms added together; one person can follow several
WNBA ID	October 2026	More than 1.7M	Members	Free account program; not League Pass subscribers
WNBA App	2026 season	More than 1.21M	Active users	Activity window not defined; 700,000 downloads
International distribution	2026	214	Countries and territories	Availability, not a measured audience

The ten measures use different units and suit different buyers, and they cannot be added together or ranked.

Source: WNBA, season 30 release, October 14, 2026; Zoomph, 2026 WNBA Regular Season Report.

Figure 19. Average regular season audience by network, 2026 DIFFERENT UNITS



ABC, CBS, ESPN, and NBC averaged 1.24 million to 1.75 million viewers a game, and ION, USA Network, and Prime Video 437,000 to 617,000. The bases differ: NBC reports total audience delivery across NBC and Peacock, ION reports windows of more than one game, and 2026 was Prime Video's first WNBA season under Nielsen measurement. ESPN's average rose 32% and ABC's and CBS's 9% each.

Source: WNBA, October 14, 2026, for ABC, CBS, ESPN, NBC, and USA Network; Front Office Sports for Prime Video and ION.

11.1 Local distribution

Ten teams put local games on free broadcast television in 2026, three on regional pay networks, Minnesota on a free streaming service, and Toronto inside Bell Media's Canadian national package. Minnesota's service, Victory+, stopped operating in September, and FOX 9+ carried the final local game. Las Vegas launched its own subscription streaming service in August 2026, and Washington sells Monumental+ at $19.99 a month or $180 a year. Local games overlap the national schedule, and no local rights fee is public.

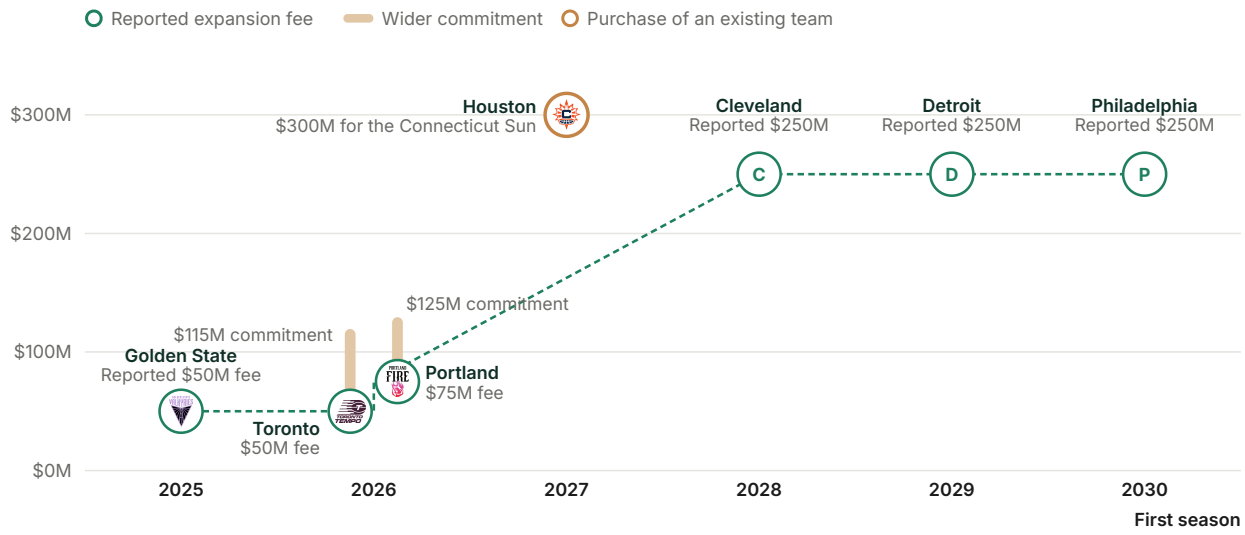
FREE BROADCAST TV	REGIONAL PAY TV	STREAMING / NATIONAL
10	**3**	**2**
Atlanta, Chicago, Dallas, Golden State, Indiana, Las Vegas, New York, Phoenix, Portland, Seattle	Connecticut, Los Angeles, Washington	Minnesota (free streaming); Toronto (Bell Media)

Source: team local broadcast announcements for all 15 teams, 2026; Bell Media; FOX 9; Cleeng, Aces streaming launch. Full table in Appendix D.

12 Expansion and entry prices

The reported price of a new WNBA team rose fivefold between the Golden State award in 2023 and the approvals of 2026. Golden State paid a reported $50M for a team that began play in 2025, and Cleveland, Detroit, and Philadelphia will pay a reported $250M each. The league does not count expansion fees as league revenue and has not said how it divides them.

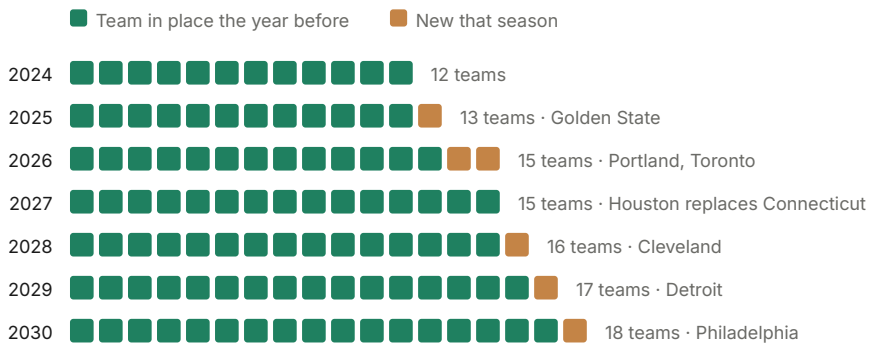
Figure 20. Reported entry prices by first season REPORTED



Reports on Toronto and Portland mix fees with wider commitments. Toronto's reported $50M fee is part of a $115M commitment, and Portland's $75M fee is part of $125M, which Insider Sport reports as the fee itself. Fertitta's $300M is a different kind of payment again, because it bought an existing franchise, with its history and roster, and moves it to Houston in 2027 without adding a team.

Source: WNBA expansion announcements; supplied expansion research cross checked to Forbes; Insider Sport, April 10, 2026; NBA.com, May 14, 2026. The league has not confirmed the $250M fees.

Figure 21. League size by season REPORTED



The league adds one team a year from 2028 to 2030. Each new team brings 22 or more home dates, a local media package, and jersey inventory, while also taking a share of league distributions, so national media and sponsorship revenue has to grow faster than the number of teams for each existing team's share to rise.

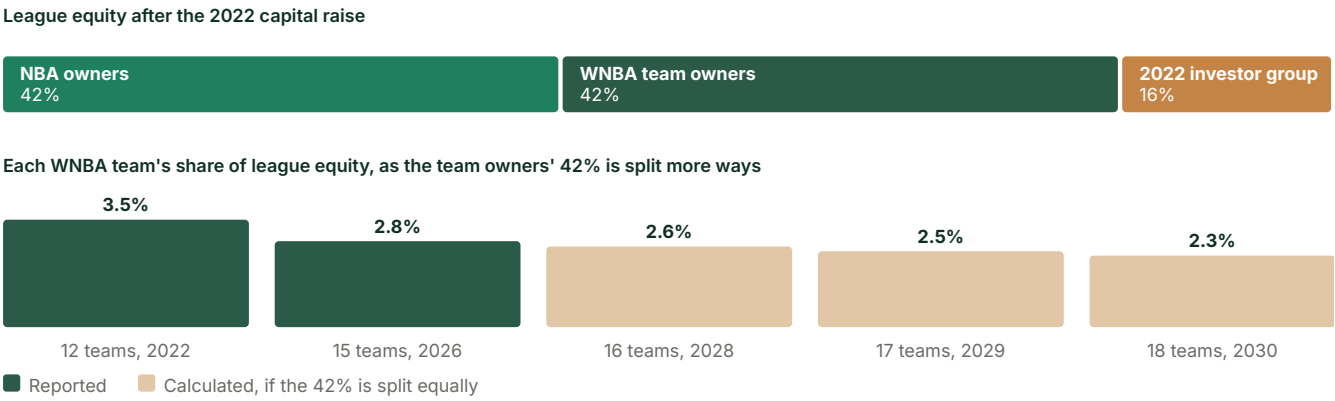
Source: WNBA expansion and relocation announcements, 2023 to 2026.

13 The league as a business

The WNBA earns money at two levels, and the split decides who benefits from each kind of growth. The league office sells national media, league sponsorship, and events, pays for officials and league operations, and sends money on to teams and players, while each team keeps its own ticket, local sponsorship, local media, and merchandise revenue. Neither the league nor any team publishes accounts, so the figures in this section come from statements, press reports, and the CBA, and each one carries the basis on which it was reported.

13.1 Who owns the league

Figure 22. WNBA league ownership and each team's share REPORTED / CALCULATED



Before 2022 the NBA owners and the WNBA teams each held half of the league. The 2022 capital raise sold 16% for $75M to a group that includes Nike, Condoleezza Rice, and Pau Gasol, which left the NBA owners and the WNBA team owners with 42% each. Expansion dilutes only the team owners' share, because every new team takes a slice of the same 42%: each team's stake fell from 3.5% to 2.8% when three teams joined, and would fall to about 2.3% at 18 teams if the split stays equal, which the league has not confirmed. Front Office Sports reported in January 2026 that the league was exploring a buyback of the 16%.

Source: Front Office Sports, January 2026 and February 2026; Sportico, 2025. Calculated shares assume the team owners' 42% is split equally among teams; the league has not published the split.

13.2 Governance

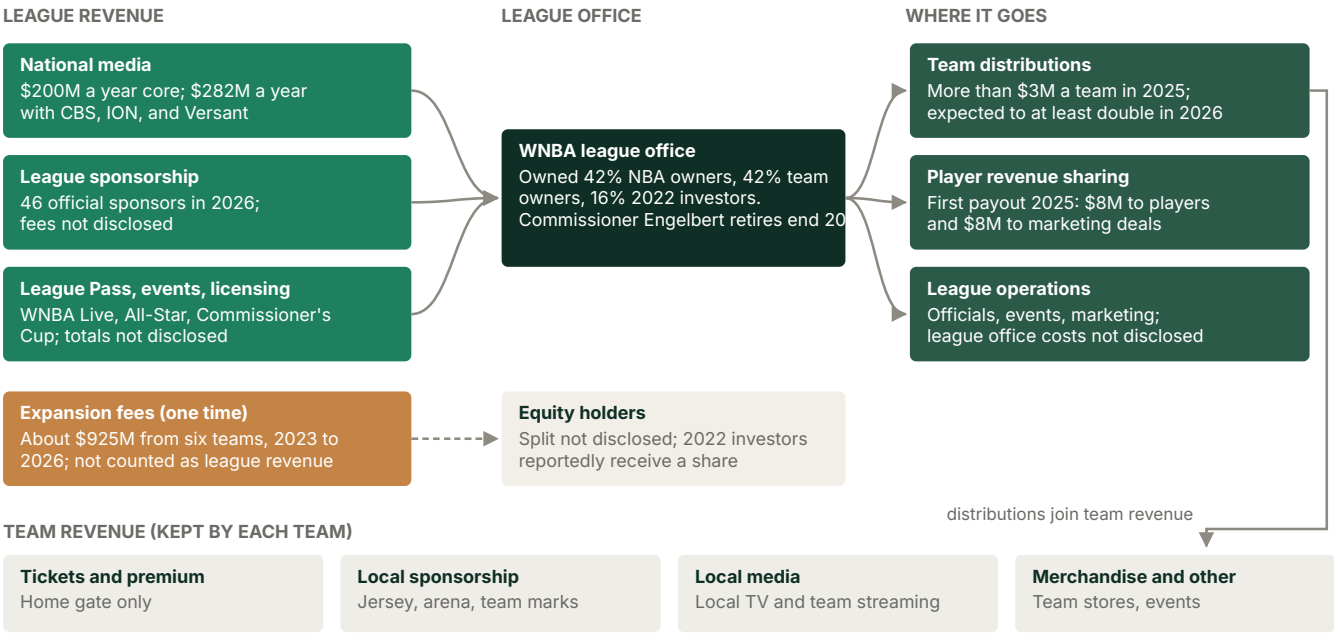
LEAGUE GOVERNANCE, OCTOBER 2026

AREA	CURRENT POSITION
Commissioner	Cathy Engelbert, the league's first commissioner, appointed in 2019. She retires at the end of 2026 and will stay into 2027 if no successor is named. NBA commissioner Adam Silver has the final say on her successor.
Owners	NBA owners and WNBA team owners hold 42% of the league each. Leonsis, the Tsais, and Simon hold stakes three ways: through their NBA teams, their WNBA teams, and the 2022 raise.
Approvals	Team sales, relocations, and expansion need approval from both the WNBA and NBA Boards of Governors, as with the Connecticut sale and the 2026 expansion awards.
Media	The NBA negotiated the core 2026 to 2036 media package for the WNBA alongside its own deals with Disney, Amazon, and NBCUniversal.

Source: Front Office Sports, September 4, 2026; ESPN, September 2026; WNBA, Connecticut Sun sale approval; NBA media agreement release.

13.3 How the money moves

Figure 23. League and team revenue, and where league money goes REPORTED



Forbes estimates the 13 teams that played in 2025 earned $430M; Sportico estimates $410M. These team totals include league distributions, so league revenue and team revenue cannot be added together.

National media is the league's largest source of money. The core contracts are worth about $200M a year, and split equally across 15 teams that would come to about $13.3M a team, nearly twice the 2026 salary cap, against a little over $3M a team in 2025 under the old contracts. The equal split is only an illustration, because the league has not said how it divides the new money between teams, players, and its equity holders. Expansion fees, about $925M since 2023, sit outside league revenue, so players receive no share of them, a point the union contested during the CBA talks.

Source: Forbes and Front Office Sports, media contract values; Sports Business Journal, sponsor count; Sportico, 2025 distributions and 2026 values; The IX Sports, 2025 revenue sharing payout; Front Office Sports, expansion fees. Dashed arrow: one time payments.

13.4 What is known about league finances

LEAGUE FINANCE DISCLOSURES, 2018 TO 2026

YEAR	FIGURE	BASIS
2018	NBA commissioner Adam Silver says the WNBA has lost more than $10M a year on average since 1997	Statement; no accounts published
2019	League revenue of $51.8M, excluding team revenue	Bloomberg, from internal league documents
2022	$75M capital raise for 16% of the league; widely reported at a $1B valuation, about $475M after the new money per Sportico	Reported
2024	Projected loss of about $50M	Washington Post report
2025	League revenue passes the CBA target for the first time: $8M paid to players and $8M added to player marketing deals	League and union payout; The IX Sports estimates
2025	More than $3M distributed to each team from national media and sponsorship	Sportico, from executives
2026	New media contracts begin; distributions expected to at least double; salary cap rises from $1.5M to $7.0M	Sportico; WNBA and WNBPA release
Lifetime	Cumulative loss of $460M, cited by a league source during CBA talks	Front Office Sports; league did not explain the figure

Source: Front Office Sports, February 21, 2026; Sportico, 2026 team values; The IX Sports, February 26, 2026; Wages of Wins, July 28, 2025 (Silver and Washington Post figures); WNBA and WNBPA CBA release, March 20, 2026.

The league's own record shows losses, including a projected 2024 loss of about $50M reported by the Washington Post, while between the 2025 and 2026 Forbes studies the value of the 12 teams valued in both years rose 41%, expansion fees reached $250M, and the Sun sold for $300M. Both records can hold at once, because buyers pay for media and sponsorship revenue they expect to grow and the losses describe seasons already played. The losses are also a limited guide to how the teams are doing. Stanford economist Roger Noll told Front Office Sports that team income statements reveal little to outsiders because private owners can move costs between the businesses they own, and that applies most to the six teams inside NBA operating groups covered in Section 14.

14 Ownership structure and shared resources

Six teams belong to the operating group of an NBA team: Golden State, Indiana, Minnesota, New York, Phoenix, and Washington. Los Angeles sits next to that group, because its lead owner, Mark Walter, took control of the Lakers in October 2025 while the Sparks continue to run as a separate organization. Las Vegas belongs to Mark Davis, who owns the NFL's Raiders, and Portland to RAJ Sports, which owns the NWSL's Thorns. The Mohegan Tribe owned Connecticut and its arena until the 2026 sale to Tilman Fertitta, who owns the Rockets, and five teams belong to investor groups with no other major team. The structure matters commercially because it decides who runs a team's arena, whether the team shares sales and service staff with another team, and whether a sponsor can buy NBA and WNBA inventory in one deal.

14.1 Who owns each team

OWNERSHIP STRUCTURE BY TEAM, OCTOBER 2026

TEAM	LEAD OWNERS	OTHER MAJOR TEAMS	SINCE	STRUCTURE
Golden State	Joe Lacob, Peter Guber	Golden State Warriors (NBA)	2023, expansion award	NBA team's operating group
Indiana	Herb Simon	Indiana Pacers (NBA)	2000, founding	NBA team's operating group

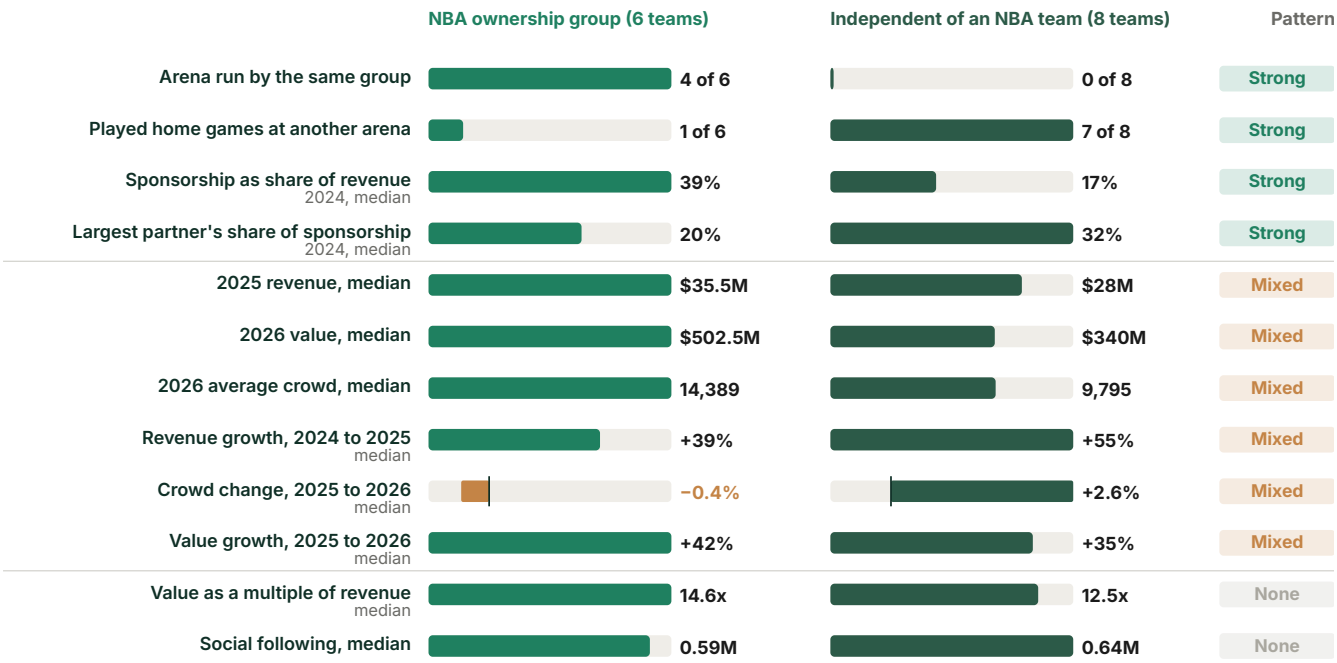
TEAM	LEAD OWNERS	OTHER MAJOR TEAMS	SINCE	STRUCTURE
Minnesota	Alex Rodriguez, Marc Lore; Marc Stad agreed in August 2026 to buy control, pending approval by the NBA and WNBA Boards of Governors	Minnesota Timberwolves (NBA)	2025, bought with the Timberwolves for $1.5B	NBA team's operating group
New York	Joe Tsai, Clara Wu Tsai	Brooklyn Nets (NBA)	2019	NBA team's operating group
Phoenix	Mat Ishbia	Phoenix Suns (NBA)	2023, bought with the Suns	NBA team's operating group
Washington	Ted Leonsis	Wizards (NBA), Capitals (NHL)	2005	NBA team's operating group
Los Angeles	Mark Walter, Magic Johnson, Todd Boehly, and partners	Dodgers (MLB); Walter controls the Lakers (NBA) from Oct 2025	2014	NBA owner, separate operation
Las Vegas	Mark Davis	Las Vegas Raiders (NFL)	2021	Owner of another major team
Portland	Lisa Bhathal Merage, Alex Bhathal (RAJ Sports)	Portland Thorns (NWSL)	2024, expansion award	Owner of another major team
Connecticut	Mohegan Tribe; Tilman Fertitta from the 2026 sale	Fertitta owns the Houston Rockets (NBA)	2003; sold 2026	Tribal casino owner; NBA group from 2027
Atlanta	Larry Gottesdiener, Suzanne Abair, Renee Montgomery	None	2021	Independent investor group
Chicago	Michael Alter	None	2006, founding	Independent investor group
Dallas	Bill Cameron and partners	None	2010, as the Tulsa Shock	Independent investor group
Seattle	Ginny Gilder, Lisa Brummel, Dawn Trudeau (Force 10)	None	2008	Independent investor group
Toronto	Larry Tanenbaum (Kilmer Sports Ventures)	None since Kilmer sold its MLSE stake to Rogers, Oct 2026	2024, expansion award	Independent investor group

Source: league approvals and team announcements; NBA, Timberwolves and Lynx sale approval, June 24, 2025; Lakers sale closing, October 30, 2025; NBA.com, Connecticut Sun sale, May 14, 2026; Global News, Rogers completes purchase of Kilmer's MLSE stake, October 1, 2026; ESPN, Fox Business, and TSN, Stad agreement for the Timberwolves and Lynx, August 21 and 22, 2026; Sportico, Storm stake sale, 2025. Minority investors are not listed.

Most changes of ownership since 2023 have brought teams closer to the NBA. The Suns and Timberwolves sales included their WNBA teams, and in August 2026 Marc Stad agreed to buy most of Marc Lore's stake in the Timberwolves and Lynx at a reported $4.5B valuation for both teams, pending approval by the NBA and WNBA Boards of Governors, with Alex Rodriguez remaining the Lynx governor; the Sparks' lead owner bought control of the Lakers, and the Sun sold to the Rockets owner. Cleveland, Detroit, and Philadelphia all join inside NBA groups between 2028 and 2030, which will put 10 of 18 teams in an NBA team's operating group. Toronto is the exception: its owner sold his stake in the Raptors' parent company in October 2026, which leaves the Tempo without an NBA connection.

14.2 Patterns in NBA group ownership

Figure 24. Twelve measures compared, NBA ownership group against independent teams PLAYBOOK STRATEGIES ANALYSIS



NBA groups run the arenas for 4 of their 6 teams, and none of the 8 independent teams has that arrangement, which helps explain why 7 of the 8 independent teams played home games away from their main arena in 2026, six of them in bigger arenas, while only one NBA group team did. In the 2024 base, sponsorship made up 39% of revenue at NBA group teams against 17% at independent teams, and the largest single partner held 20% of the total against 32%, so independent teams earned less from sponsorship and relied more on one deal.

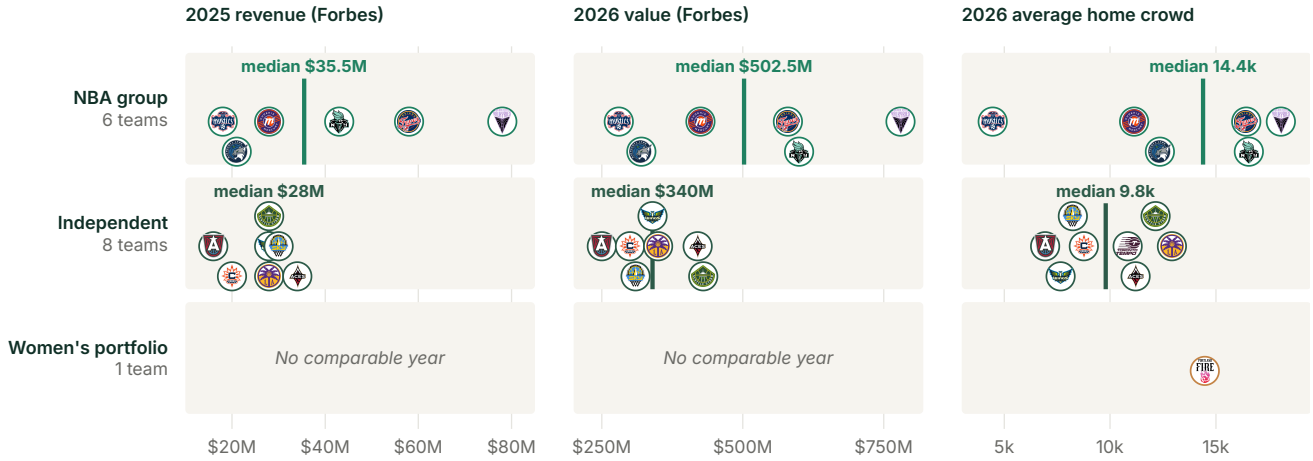
Part of the sponsorship gap may come from the method, because the estimates split deals covering several teams between those teams and some NBA team deals count toward the WNBA team. That still reflects joint selling, though it overstates what the WNBA team sells by itself.

Source: Playbook Strategies analysis. Forbes, May 2025 and May 2026; 2026 game records; Playbook Strategies sponsorship analysis (2024 base); Zoomph social snapshot. Independent means the eight teams outside an NBA team's operating group, excluding Portland. Revenue measures exclude Golden State in 2024 and Toronto. Bars compare the two groups within each row.

NBA group teams earn more, are worth more, and draw larger crowds, while independent teams grew revenue faster from 2024 to 2025, led by Chicago (88%), Dallas (87%), and Los Angeles (75%). NBA group crowds were flat in 2026, with Golden State selling out every game and Indiana averaging 95% of its highest recorded crowd. Value multiples and social following show no pattern, and teams with small revenue reach about 15 times revenue in both groups. The comparison does not, on its own, isolate the effect of ownership, because the two groups also differ in market size and arena access, and those differences account for part of each gap.

14.3 Revenue, value, and crowds by team

Figure 25. 2025 revenue, 2026 value, and 2026 crowds by ownership model REPORTED / CALCULATED



Each logo is one team, and the line marks the group median. The spread inside each group is wide: Washington belongs to an NBA group and has the league's smallest crowds in a 4,200 seat arena, while Seattle and Las Vegas reached values of $430M and $420M without an NBA owner.

Source: Forbes, May 2026; 2026 game records; team ownership and operating disclosures. Connecticut counts as independent for 2026. Portland and Toronto have no Forbes estimate.

14.4 Shared resources

ARENA, LOCAL TV AND SHARED RESOURCES BY TEAM, 2026

TEAM	ARENA	LOCAL TV	SHARED RESOURCES IN PUBLIC EVIDENCE
Golden State	Same group runs arena	Free broadcast	Warriors arena, insight staff, joint sponsor deals
Indiana	Same group runs arena	Free broadcast	PS&E runs arena; $78M center funded by PS&E
Minnesota	Tenant	Free streaming	Common Timberwolves and Lynx organization
New York	Same group runs arena	Free broadcast	BSE Global runs Barclays Center
Phoenix	Same group runs arena	Free broadcast	Shared Suns and Mercury campus, $100M
Washington	Tenant	Regional pay TV	Monumental owns team, Wizards, and local network
Atlanta	Tenant, two arenas	Free broadcast	None documented
Chicago	Tenant	Free broadcast	None; own $38M training center
Connecticut	Tenant	Regional pay TV	None in 2026; Rockets owner from 2027
Dallas	Tenant, two arenas	Free broadcast	None; city grant for training center
Las Vegas	Tenant	Free broadcast	None documented
Los Angeles	Tenant	Regional pay TV	None; own $150M training center
Seattle	Tenant	Free broadcast	None; own $64M training center
Toronto	Tenant	Canadian national package	None documented
Portland	Tenant	Free broadcast	Campus shared with the Thorns, over $150M

Source: team, league, and venue announcements; facility announcements in Section 8; local broadcast announcements in Section 11. Common ownership does not quantify a subsidy, and no team discloses shared service charges.

Teams in NBA groups share arenas, campuses, staff, or media networks with the NBA team, and none of them discloses what it pays for those services. Independent teams have paid for their own training centers, including Seattle's $64M center, Chicago's $38M center, and Los Angeles's $150M center. Section 16 shows how the shared model worked in Golden State's first two seasons.

15 Team by team: 15 commercial profiles

Each profile gives the team's 2026 crowd, 2025 revenue and 2026 value estimates, jersey partners, and local TV, followed by its commercial position. The small line shows average crowd from 2024 to 2026 on the same scale for every team.

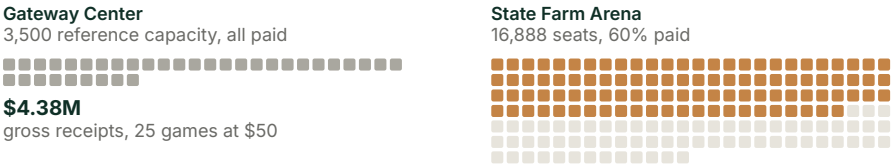
Atlanta

INDEPENDENT OF AN NBA TEAM

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
6,928	**$16M**	**$250M · 15.6x**	None listed / Albert	Free broadcast
+54.7% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Atlanta had the league's smallest 2025 revenue estimate, $16M. In 2026 it played 16 home games at the Gateway Center, which has a reference capacity of 3,500, and averaged 3,592 there. Its six games at State Farm Arena drew 15,827 a game, and every home game moves there in 2027, which gives the team more seats, premium inventory, and signage to sell. Atlanta traded for Angel Reese in April 2026, reached the Finals, and grew its social engagements 119% and its social value 182% on 2025, the fastest growth in the league on Zoomph's figures. How much of that audience becomes revenue in 2027 depends on lease terms and seat targets the team has not published.

Figure 26. Atlanta gross ticket receipts, Gateway Center against State Farm Arena MODELED



Each square is 100 seats. Filled squares are paid seats in the scenario.

At the same $50 yield, filling 60% of State Farm Arena's 16,888 seats for 25 games returns $12.7M in gross receipts against $4.4M from a full Gateway Center, a gain of $8.3M before rent, event costs, and the lease split. The scenario shows the scale of the move and is not a forecast of Atlanta's 2027 revenue.

Source: Playbook Strategies model, from the supplied Atlanta research. Assumes 25 home games and $50 gross per paid admission at both arenas; capacities from Gateway Center Arena and State Farm Arena. Gateway's announced 2026 crowds averaged 3,592, slightly above the 3,500 reference capacity used here, because capacities change with seating configuration (Appendix C.3).

Chicago

INDEPENDENT OF AN NBA TEAM

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
8,237	**$30M**	**$310M · 10.3x**	UChicago Medicine / Magellan Corporation	Free broadcast
−9.2% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Chicago's average crowd fell 9.2% in 2026, while Forbes estimates that its 2025 revenue rose 88% to $30M, the fifth highest; the two figures cover different seasons, so the fall in crowds does not yet show in a revenue estimate. Its two United Center games drew 13,770 a game against 7,684 at Wintrust Arena. The team opened a $38M training center in 2026 that it funds without an NBA partner.

Connecticut

INDEPENDENT OF AN NBA TEAM

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
8,762	**$20M**	**$300M · 15.0x**	Yale New Haven Health / None listed	Regional pay TV
+1.3% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Connecticut played its last season at Mohegan Sun Arena, which the Mohegan Tribe owns, as it owned the team until the 2026 sale. Tilman Fertitta paid $300M and moves the team to Houston in 2027, where the Rockets owner's group will run it. Its three games in Hartford and Boston averaged 13,811 against 7,964 at Mohegan Sun, which gives some indication of demand in larger markets. In Houston the team needs a new season ticket base, a new local TV deal, and new sponsors.

Dallas

INDEPENDENT OF AN NBA TEAM

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
7,658	**$28M**	**$340M · 12.1x**	CVS / Albert	Free broadcast
+5.3% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Dallas drew 6,237 a game at College Park Center and 16,659 at its three American Airlines Center games before moving to the AAC full time in 2027, and its road crowds averaged 13,240, second only to Indiana. Zoomph ranked it second for social value in 2026 at $11.6M, and CVS on its jersey front averaged 96,000 logo impressions a post, second to Salesforce. The team publishes the most detailed price maps captured, with 2026 renewal prices from $25 to $450 a game, and 2027 will show whether those prices hold in a far larger arena.

Golden State

NBA OWNERSHIP GROUP

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
18,064	**$78M**	**$780M · 10.0x**	Kaiser Permanente / Chase Freedom	Free broadcast
+0.0% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Golden State sold all 22 home games at Chase Center in both of its seasons, had the highest 2025 revenue estimate at $78M, and reported more than $100M for 2026. It started with partners in hand, because it belongs to the Warriors' ownership group and five of its eight founding partners already had Warriors or Chase Center deals. Section 16 covers the team in detail.

Indiana

NBA OWNERSHIP GROUP

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
16,426	**$58M**	**$580M · 10.0x**	Salesforce / Lilly	Free broadcast
−0.8% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Indiana leads the league on most audience measures, with 3.26 billion impressions on its social accounts in the 2026 regular season, $106M of social value on Zoomph's estimate, and road crowds of 15,117. Home crowds slipped 0.8% to 16,426, 95% of its highest recorded crowd, so further growth depends on price, premium seating, and sponsorship. Pacers Sports & Entertainment runs the arena and is paying for a $78M Fever training center due in 2027. Section 17 covers the team in detail.

Las Vegas

INDEPENDENT OF AN NBA TEAM

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
11,206	**$34M**	**$420M · 12.4x**	IPSY / Ally	Free broadcast
−3.0% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Las Vegas announced a blended 17.65% increase in 2027 season ticket prices, without stating the game count behind it, and says 72% of its season tickets still cost under $35 a game. Its owner, Mark Davis, also owns the NFL's Raiders. The team plays most games at MGM's Michelob ULTRA Arena, where crowds averaged 10,336, and drew 16,715 a game at its three games at T-Mobile Arena. It launched its own subscription streaming service in August 2026, and its sponsorship depends heavily on one partner, Ally, which accounted for 53% of the 2024 base.

Los Angeles

INDEPENDENT OF AN NBA TEAM

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
12,919	**$28M**	**$350M · 12.5x**	UCLA Health / Albert	Regional pay TV
+3.8% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Los Angeles grew its average crowd for a second year, to 12,919, and Forbes estimates that its 2025 revenue rose 75% to $28M. Its $150M El Segundo training center, due in 2027, is the largest budget for a center built for one WNBA team and more than five times that revenue estimate. Local games air on Spectrum SportsNet, a regional pay network. Its lead owner, Mark Walter, took control of the Lakers in October 2025, and the two teams run as separate organizations.

Minnesota

NBA OWNERSHIP GROUP

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
12,351	**$21M**	**$320M · 15.2x**	Mayo Clinic / None listed	Free streaming
+24.0% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Minnesota had the second largest crowd growth among returning teams after Atlanta, up 24% to 12,351, and the West's best record at 33–11, and Zoomph ranked it third for social value in 2026 at $9.44M. Its 2025 revenue estimate of $21M is among the lowest, and Forbes values the team at 15.2 times revenue, which suggests buyers expect that revenue to grow. Its local streaming partner, Victory+, shut down in September 2026, so the team goes into 2027 without a local media partner.

New York

NBA OWNERSHIP GROUP

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
16,543	**$43M**	**$600M · 14.0x**	Liberty Mutual / Barclays	Free broadcast
+1.4% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

New York had $11.0M of estimated sponsorship across 47 deals in the 2024 licensed database, second only to Phoenix. Fan renewal records show general seats holding their price per game for 2027 while premium seats rise 20% to 25%, so the increases fall on the seats with the most demand. BSE Global runs Barclays Center, and the team plans an $80M training center in Brooklyn for 2027.

Phoenix

NBA OWNERSHIP GROUP

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
11,128	**$28M**	**$425M · 15.2x**	Fry's Food Stores / Hero Bread	Free broadcast
−1.6% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Phoenix had the largest 2024 sponsorship base in the Playbook Strategies analysis, though Bally's accounted for 39% of it, which leaves the total exposed to a single renewal. It shows 36 local games on free television and streaming, the most of any team. Courtside renewals rose 26% to 41% per game for 2027. The team shares a $100M campus and its operating group with the Suns.

Portland

WOMEN'S SPORTS PORTFOLIO

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
14,469	**n.a.**	**n.a.**	Lashify / Chime	Free broadcast
New team	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Portland averaged 14,469 in its first season, fourth in the league, and has Lashify on the front of the jersey and Chime on the shoulder. Its owner, RAJ Sports, also owns the NWSL's Portland Thorns, and the two teams share a training campus that cost more than $150M. Portland has no Forbes estimate yet, so the 2027 figures will give the first comparison between a team run inside a women's sports group and the teams in NBA groups.

Seattle

INDEPENDENT OF AN NBA TEAM

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
12,142	**$28M**	**$430M · 15.4x**	Providence Swedish / Symetra	Free broadcast
+2.6% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Seattle owns its $64M training and business center, opened in 2024, and rents Climate Pledge Arena from Oak View Group. Crowds rose 2.6% to 12,142, and its local games air on broadcast TV and stream on Prime Video in Washington state. Forbes values the team at 15.4 times its 2025 revenue estimate of $28M, the second highest multiple among teams without an NBA owner, after Atlanta's 15.6 times.

Toronto

INDEPENDENT OF AN NBA TEAM

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
10,828	**n.a.**	**n.a.**	CIBC / Sephora	Canadian national package
New team	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Toronto drew 8,205 a game at the Coca-Cola Coliseum and 16,449 at its seven games in larger arenas in Toronto, Montreal, and Vancouver, including a team record 20,996 on July 10, so those seven dates supplied about half of its home visits. Its games air nationally on TSN under Bell Media's Canadian deal, and the team plans a C$100M training center for 2028. Its owner, Kilmer Sports Ventures, sold its 25% stake in MLSE, the Raptors' parent company, to Rogers in October 2026, which leaves the team without an NBA connection.

Washington

NBA OWNERSHIP GROUP

2026 AVERAGE CROWD	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	JERSEY: FRONT / SHOULDER	LOCAL TV
4,454	**$18M**	**$280M · 15.6x**	Vanda Pharmaceuticals / CarMax	Regional pay TV
−16.0% on 2025	Forbes estimate	Forbes; value / revenue		

Washington played 21 of 22 home games at CareFirst Arena, and every one drew 4,200, the arena's reference capacity, so its 16% fall in average crowd reflects playing fewer games in bigger arenas than in 2025. Renewal invoices for 2027 show the steepest increases in the samples, 42% to 57% per game, and its social impressions rose 44% on 2025, the third fastest growth in the league. Monumental Sports & Entertainment owns the team, the Wizards, and the regional network that carries its games. Section 18 covers the team in detail.

16 Case study: Golden State

Golden State is the clearest example of a team started inside an NBA group, and the 2026 Finals put it against Atlanta, the team with the lowest 2025 revenue estimate. The series stood at 2–2 on October 25.

16.1 Golden State: a sold out arena

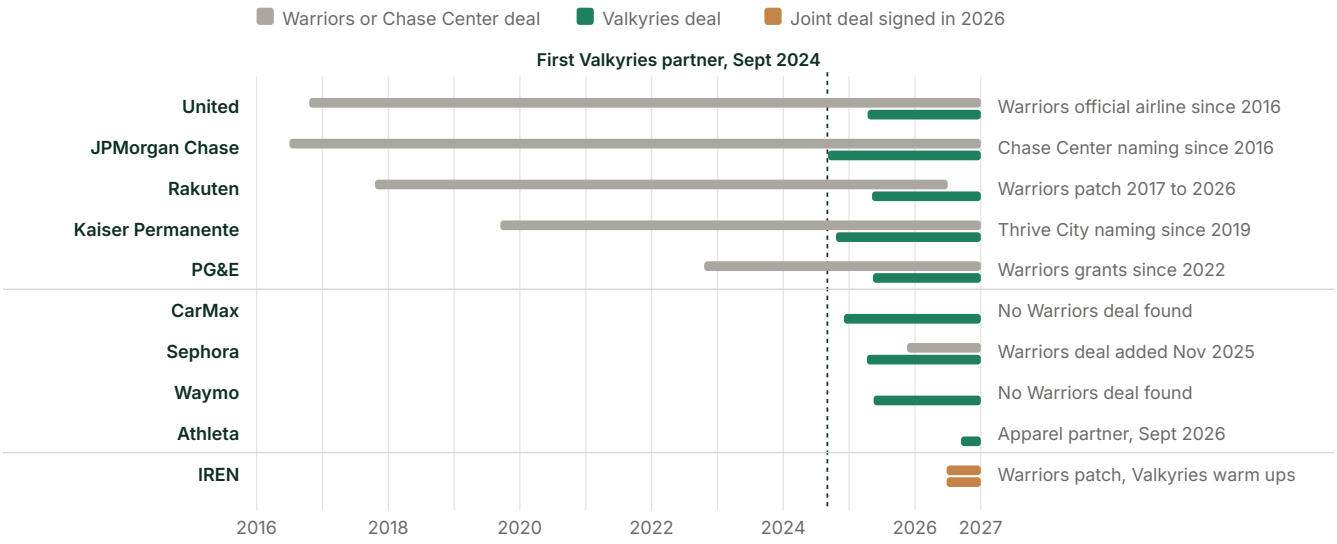
AVERAGE HOME CROWD	SEASON TICKET HOLDERS	2025 REVENUE	FORBES VALUE, 2026
18,064	**12,000+**	**$78M**	**$780M**
All 22 games sold out, 2025 and 2026	A team record; over 90% renewed for 2027	Forbes estimate; over $100M in 2026, per Sportico	Highest in the league; CNBC: $1B

Golden State belongs to the Warriors ownership group, plays at Chase Center, and trains at the Sephora Performance Center in Oakland. Chase Center has sold out every home game since 2025, so revenue growth now depends on price, premium seating, and sponsorship. The 26 community records show 2027 renewal prices rising 5.5% to 11.1% per game, and one separately posted invoice for Section 110 shows 16.7%, and Sportico expects a Finals run to lift 2026 gross revenue past $130M.

16.2 Why Golden State started from a strong base

Golden State began with three things Portland and Toronto did not have: the Warriors' Bay Area sponsors and sales staff, demand for season tickets from buyers the Warriors were not serving, and a playoff team in its first season. The table below sets out five claims behind those three advantages, the public evidence for each, and what is still missing.

Figure 27. Golden State's partners, by which team signed them first PUBLIC PAGE COUNT



Five of the eight founding partners already had a Warriors or Chase Center deal: Chase, Kaiser Permanente, United, Rakuten, and PG&E. Three had none in their announcements: CarMax, Sephora, and Waymo, and in November 2025 Sephora became the first Valkyries partner to add a Warriors deal. In June 2026 IREN replaced Rakuten on the Warriors jersey in a deal reported at about $50M a year, and the same agreement put IREN on the Valkyries warm ups.

Source: Team and partner announcements, 2016 to 2026; Insider Sport, September 6, 2024; Sephora newsroom, November 18, 2025; IREN, June 25, 2026; Sportcal, June 26, 2026; Digiday, October 9, 2026. Fees are not public except the reported IREN figure. Selected partners; the team reports more than 40.

FIVE CLAIMS ABOUT GOLDEN STATE'S START, TESTED AGAINST PUBLIC EVIDENCE

CLAIM	WHAT THE PUBLIC RECORD SHOWS	WHAT IS STILL MISSING
The Warriors relationship supplied the first partners	Five of eight founding partners had Warriors or Chase Center deals. Valkyries president Jess Smith said in May 2025 that some Warriors sponsors were "first in line". The two teams share an eight person partnership insights team.	Fees, and how joint deals such as IREN's split between the teams
The Valkyries sold to sponsors the Warriors had not signed	CarMax, Waymo, and Athleta show no Warriors deal. Sephora started with the Valkyries and later bought Warriors inventory. Smith said there "was never an assumption" of "two for one" deals because the fan base differs. The team reported more than 40 partners and 30% growth in partnership revenue in October 2026.	Whether Warriors inventory was sold out in the categories the Valkyries filled
Bay Area tech and AI brands are a local advantage	Waymo (driverless rides), IREN (AI cloud), and Rakuten (online retail) are Valkyries partners. The two jersey patches are a bank card and a health system, the same mix as the rest of the league.	The full partner list by category, compared with other teams
Season tickets sold to a different buyer	Under 5% of season ticket holders also held Warriors seats in May 2025, and 8% in October 2026. The team sold 10,000 season tickets from more than 22,000 deposits before its first game. Sampled 2026 prices have a median of $100 a game, and some seats renew at $31 to $34.	How the team counts overlap, and a comparable Warriors price map
Winning supported both	Golden State was the first expansion team to reach the playoffs in its first season, in 2025. It went 32–12 in 2026 and reached the Finals.	A way to separate the effect of winning from the effect of the market

Source: SportsPro, May 15, 2025; Digiday, October 9, 2026; Yahoo Sports, October 2026; Golden State Valkyries releases; CBS Sports, 2025 playoffs; Playbook Strategies ticket sample (Section 7).

The Warriors relationship supplied Golden State's first partners, its sales and insight staff, and its arena. The Valkyries then signed brands such as CarMax, Waymo, Sephora, and Athleta, sold existing partners inventory with a different audience, and sold season tickets to people who did not hold Warriors seats. The local NBA team's owners own Cleveland, Detroit, and Philadelphia, so those teams can start the same way, while Portland's owner runs no NBA team and Toronto's owner no longer holds a stake in the Raptors. Golden State's first two seasons are therefore a closer guide to the next three expansion teams than to the two that joined in 2026.

17 Case study: Indiana and the audience question

Indiana drafted Caitlin Clark first overall in 2024. The Fever averaged about 4,000 a game in 2023 and 17,036 in 2024, and Forbes estimated 2024 revenue of $32M, the highest in the league that year. Clark played 40 of 44 regular season games in 2026 after missing 31 in 2025 through injury. Indiana averaged 95% of its highest recorded crowd in 2026, so the commercial question is how much of its national audience the team can turn into its own revenue.

AVERAGE HOME CROWD
16,426
2026; 17,274, its highest, at 9 of 22 games

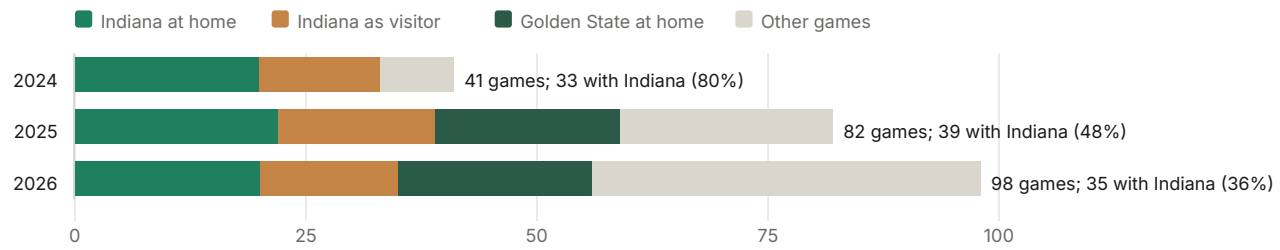
AVERAGE ROAD CROWD
15,117
Largest in the league; 32% above average

2025 REVENUE
$58M
Forbes; up from $32M in 2024

FORBES VALUE, 2026
$580M
Up 57% on 2025

17.1 The Caitlin Clark effect in the crowd data

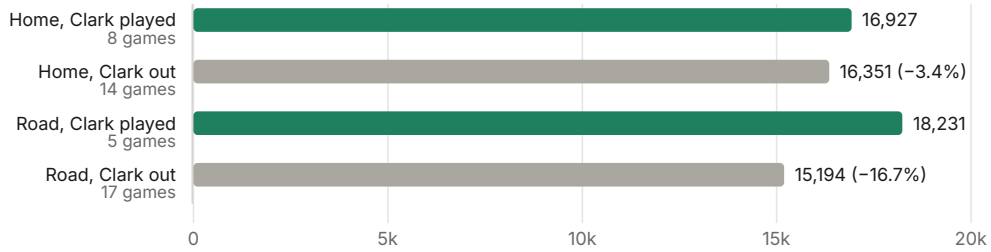
Figure 28. Regular season crowds of 15,000 or more, by who played CALCULATED



Crowds of 15,000 or more rose from 41 in 2024 to 98 in 2026. Indiana played in 33 of the 41 in 2024, or 80%, and in 35 of the 98 in 2026, or 36%. The number of big crowds involving Indiana held steady while the rest of the league added them: Golden State sold 18,064 at every home game from 2025, and other teams added 34 more. Opponents still move games against Indiana to bigger arenas. Six of the 26 home games teams played away from their main arena in 2026 were against the Fever, and those six averaged 17,924.

Source: Across the Timeline, game records for 2024 to 2026, regular season only.

Figure 29. Indiana's 2025 crowds with and without Caitlin Clark CALCULATED



In the 2025 games Clark missed, home crowds were 3.4% lower and road crowds 16.7% lower than in the games she played. Indiana had sold out its 2025 season tickets by late March, which held home crowds up, while single game buyers on the road could decide closer to the game. The two sets of games also differ in opponent, date, and arena, so the comparison shows lower crowds in the games she missed and does not, on its own, isolate her effect on demand.

Source: Across the Timeline, 2025 game records; Clark's availability from the 2025 Fever game log. Announced attendance counts tickets distributed, including tickets sold before an injury was known.

17.2 The audience outside the arena

Every national partner's most watched regular season game of 2026 included Indiana. Zoomph counted 3.26 billion impressions and 88.1 million engagements on the Fever's accounts in the 2026 regular season, 9.2 times the average team's impressions and 7 times its engagement, and valued that exposure at $106M, more than any NBA team's accounts produced in the 2025/26 NBA season. Indiana's impressions rose 142% on 2025 with Clark back for most of the season. The team's partners share in that audience: Salesforce and Lilly averaged 427,000 and 420,000 logo impressions per post in 2026, more than three times any other jersey partner in the league, and Indiana's own posts produced about 93% of Salesforce's exposure.

EACH NATIONAL PARTNER'S MOST WATCHED REGULAR SEASON GAME, 2026

NETWORK	MOST WATCHED 2026 REGULAR SEASON GAME	AVERAGE VIEWERS
ABC	Sky at Fever, Aug. 8	2.56M
CBS	Fever at Liberty, July 18	2.58M
ESPN	Dream at Fever, Aug. 16	2.60M
NBC / Peacock	Sky at Fever, Aug. 23	3.31M
ION	Wings at Fever, Aug. 14	1.62M
Prime Video	Wings at Fever, Aug. 20	1.07M
USA Network	Fever at Valkyries, July 15	1.14M

Source: WNBA, season 30 release, October 14, 2026. NBC and Peacock report total audience delivery across platforms.

17.3 Where the money goes

Much of the money that Indiana's audience generates goes to other teams. The league shares national media money across all 15 teams and ticket revenue stays with the home team, so the 332,568 fans who watched Indiana on the road in 2026 bought their tickets from Indiana's opponents. What Indiana keeps is its home gate, its local media, its sponsors, and its merchandise, and each of those has its own limit.

- **Tickets.** Indiana drew 17,274, its highest recorded crowd, at 9 of 22 home games in 2026 and averaged 95% of that figure, so further ticket growth has to come mostly from price. The team has already moved on price: entry season tickets rose from $32 a game in 2023 to $40 in 2024 and $50 in 2025, and courtside seats rose 38% to $690 a game in 2025. The 2027 package includes 26 home events.
- **Sponsorship.** SponsorUnited counted 92 Fever brand partners in 2024, the most of any team. Salesforce has held the front of the jersey since 2019 and Lilly took the shoulder patch in 2024, and Zoomph's 2026 figures put both at the top of their asset lists for logo exposure.
- **Local media.** WTHR and WALV carried 18 games in 2026, and the team's own service, Fever Direct, streams up to 18 regular season games. Neither the rights fee nor the subscriber count is public, which makes local media the part of Indiana's revenue that outsiders can least measure.
- **Dependence on one player.** Road crowds were 16.7% lower in the 2025 games Clark missed, though those games also differ in opponent and arena. Indiana exercised Clark's fourth year option for 2027.

Source: IBJ, April 11, 2025 and May 1, 2024; SportsPro, 2025 season review (SponsorUnited data); Fever Direct; 2025 Fever season game log; Basketball Reference, games played; TMZ and Bleacher Report for the 2023 average.

18 Case study: Washington and the small arena

Washington plays in a 4,200 seat arena, the second smallest in the league after Atlanta's Gateway Center, and sells nearly every seat, which leaves price as the main way to grow ticket revenue. Monumental Sports & Entertainment owns the Mystics, the Wizards, the Capitals, Capital One Arena, and the regional network that carries Mystics games.

CAREFIRST ARENA CROWDS
4,200
Every home game there, 2024 to 2026: 55 games

2027 RENEWALS
+22% to +50%
Per game, per the team's renewal chart

AVERAGE RESALE PRICE
$146
Third highest in the league; up 26%

2025 REVENUE
$18M
Forbes; value $280M, up 37%

18.1 A fixed arena and a changing average

Figure 30. Washington's home crowds by arena, 2024 to 2026 REPORTED

SEASON	CAREFIRST GAMES	CAREFIRST AVERAGE	GAMES ELSEWHERE	AVERAGE ELSEWHERE	OTHER VENUES	SEASON AVERAGE
2024	16	4,200	4	15,908	Capital One Arena	**6,542**
2025	18	4,200	4	10,266	CFG Bank Arena, EagleBank Arena	**5,303**
2026	21	4,200	1	9,798	Capital One Arena	**4,454**

All 55 games at CareFirst Arena over three seasons drew 4,200. The team's average fell from 6,542 in 2024 to 4,454 in 2026 because it played fewer games elsewhere: four at Capital One Arena in 2024, including two against Indiana that drew 20,333 and 20,711; four in Baltimore and Fairfax in 2025; and one at Capital One Arena in 2026.

Source: Across the Timeline, game records for 2024 to 2026. Events DC runs CareFirst Arena; Washington's lease runs through 2037.

18.2 Pricing a scarce seat

Washington was among the first teams to send 2027 renewals, in mid July 2026. The team's renewal chart shows prices per game rising roughly 22% to 50%, and the same seat examples in Section 7 rise 42% to 57% per game. One stands seat goes from $51.14 to $76.50 a game. One floor seat package goes from $4,207.50 in 2025 to $6,907.50 in 2026 and $10,200 in 2027. The team cites three more home games and rising operating costs, says player salaries were not a factor, and calls its prices among the most affordable in the league.

SeatGeek reports an average Mystics resale price of $146, the third highest in the league. That average covers every seat location and game sold on the resale market, so it does not compare directly with the renewal price of any one seat. With 4,200 seats and 25 home games in 2027, each $10 added to every seat brings about $1.05M in gross receipts, about a quarter of what the same increase brings in an 18,000 seat arena. The team plans more games at Capital One Arena from 2028, after its renovation.

18.3 Sponsorship and media inside one group

Washington's 2024 sponsorship base came from 52 deals, the most of any team, with a median of $41,500 a deal and Robinhood the largest at 20% of the total. Vanda Pharmaceuticals holds the front of the jersey and CarMax the shoulder. Monumental Sports Network carried 32 regular season games in 2026 and sells its Monumental+ streaming service at $19.99 a month. Monumental owns both the team and the network and has not published the rights fee.

Source: Front Office Sports, August 4 and 8, 2026; Washington renewal examples in Section 7; Monumental Sports Network, 2026 schedule; Events DC; Playbook Strategies sponsorship analysis (Appendix C.10).

19 Player costs under the new CBA

The WNBA and the WNBPA agreed a seven year CBA in March 2026, running through 2032. It raised the 2026 salary cap to $7.0M from $1.5M and expands and restructures revenue sharing, with the cap adjusting each year to growth in league and team revenue. Revenue sharing already existed under the 2020 agreement, which promised players half of revenue above set growth targets from 2021; league revenue passed those targets for the first time in 2025, when $8M went to players and $8M to player marketing deals (Section 13). The league projects more than $1B in player salaries and benefits over the term.

KEY CBA TERMS

TERM	2025	2026	BY 2032
Salary cap	$1.5M	$7.0M	Adjusts each year with league and team revenue
Average salary	$120,000	$583,000	More than $1M
Maximum salary	Not captured	$1.4M	More than $2.4M
Minimum salary	Not captured	$270,000 to $300,000	$340,000 to $380,000
No. 1 draft pick	Not captured	$500,000 (projected)	Not stated
Regular season games	44	44	Up to 50 in 2027 and 2028; up to 52 from 2029

Source: WNBA, WNBA and WNBPA reach tentative CBA, March 20, 2026; Sportico, WNBA labor term sheet, 2026 (2025 average salary).

2026 CAP ACROSS 15 TEAMS

$105M

The cap times 15; actual payrolls are not public

CAP AT THE 13 TEAMS OF 2025

$91M

For scale: 21% of their 2025 revenue estimate

ADDED HOME DATES IN 2027

3

From 22 to 25 per team, with travel and payroll days

The salary cap covers player salaries only. The CBA also requires charter flights, league housing through 2028, expanded staffing and facility standards, and larger benefits, and the league has not priced these publicly. No team publishes accounts that would show the effect on profit. Forbes wrote in May 2026 that a few teams are already profitable.

Three more home dates a team in 2027 add ticket, sponsorship, and local media inventory, and they add travel, arena, and staff costs on the same days. The renewal invoices in Section 7 already include the extra games.

20 Commercial priorities

Each priority below starts from a public finding. Turning one into a revenue plan needs the team's own sales, customer, and contract data.

PRIORITY	WHAT THE REPORT SUPPORTS	NEXT DECISION AND EVIDENCE
Growth at existing teams	The 13 returning teams added 2.8%; expansion supplied 86% of the gain	Report same team growth apart from expansion, by venue and seating configuration.
Venue moves	Atlanta and Dallas move to larger arenas in 2027	Compare paid attendance, yield, and lease retention before and after each move.
Pricing	2027 invoices include three more games; per game changes run from 0% to 57% in the samples	Obtain price per included game by seat zone, weighted by seats sold.
Partnerships	46 league sponsors with no public fees or end years; 27 jersey placements	Confirm exclusivity, term, and asset control before valuing or pitching a deal.
Ownership model	Teams in NBA groups show higher median revenue, value, and crowds; five of Golden State's eight founding partners already had Warriors or Chase Center deals	Obtain shared service charges and joint deal splits; test whether Cleveland, Detroit, and Philadelphia start the way Golden State did.
Audience valuation	Reach, average audience, views, and members use different units; much of the money from Indiana's audience goes to the league and to home teams	Match the measure to the asset and the buyer, and price what a team keeps from its own audience.
Cost base	Cap up from $1.5M to $7.0M, plus travel, facility, and staffing standards	Model payroll, travel, and facility cost per team against revenue per team.

Recommendation: measure growth team by team, on the revenue each team keeps. League totals in 2026 include two new teams and games moved to larger arenas, and from 2027 they include three more home games per team. A team, a buyer, or a sponsor needs revenue per fan at one team, and the league totals do not show it.

21 Signals worth tracking

EIGHT DATED SIGNALS WORTH TRACKING

SIGNAL	WHEN	WHAT IT WOULD TELL YOU
2026 Finals, Games 5 to 7	By October 31, 2026	Finals crowds and audiences at Chase Center and in Atlanta
Forbes 2027 valuations	May 2027	First revenue estimates for Portland and Toronto, and 2026 revenue under the new CBA
Houston's first season	2027	How a relocated franchise prices tickets and partnerships in a new market
Atlanta at State Farm Arena; Dallas at the AAC	2027	How much revenue each larger arena adds once crowds, prices, and lease terms settle
25 home games	2027	Whether price per game holds as the schedule grows
Training centers open in Indiana, Los Angeles, New York, and Dallas	2027	The operating cost of the CBA facility standards
Washington returns to Capital One Arena for more games	2028	Whether more games in a larger arena raise Washington's ticket revenue
Cleveland enters	2028	Whether a $250M entry price comes with first year demand like Portland's and Toronto's

A Appendix A: Team commercial table, 2026

RANKED BY 2026 AVERAGE HOME CROWD

TEAM	ATTENDANCE	AVERAGE	CHANGE	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	MULTIPLE	FOLLOWERS
Golden State	397,408	18,064	+0.0%	$78M	$780M	10.0x	0.40M
New York	363,956	16,543	+1.4%	$43M	$600M	14.0x	0.80M
Indiana	361,379	16,426	−0.8%	$58M	$580M	10.0x	2.90M
Portland	318,310	14,469	New	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.	0.15M
Los Angeles	284,210	12,919	+3.8%	$28M	$350M	12.5x	0.99M
Minnesota	271,730	12,351	+24.0%	$21M	$320M	15.2x	0.65M
Seattle	267,128	12,142	+2.6%	$28M	$430M	15.4x	0.50M
Las Vegas	246,524	11,206	−3.0%	$34M	$420M	12.4x	1.31M
Phoenix	244,805	11,128	−1.6%	$28M	$425M	15.2x	0.52M
Toronto	238,225	10,828	New	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.	0.21M
Connecticut	192,759	8,762	+1.3%	$20M	$300M	15.0x	0.23M
Chicago	181,211	8,237	−9.2%	$30M	$310M	10.3x	1.15M
Dallas	168,477	7,658	+5.3%	$28M	$340M	12.1x	0.73M

TEAM	ATTENDANCE	AVERAGE	CHANGE	2025 REVENUE	2026 VALUE	MULTIPLE	FOLLOWERS
Atlanta	152,426	6,928	+54.7%	$16M	$250M	15.6x	0.55M
Washington	97,998	4,454	−16.0%	$18M	$280M	15.6x	0.37M
League	**3,786,546**	**11,474**	**+4.4%**	**$430M**	**$5.39B**	**12.5x**	**11.47M**

Attendance: 2026 regular season. Revenue: Forbes 2025 estimates. Value: Forbes, May 2026. Followers: Zoomph snapshot, duplicates left in. The League row uses the exact 2025 baseline for the change in average crowd; team changes use rounded 2025 averages.

B Appendix B: Attendance by venue, 2026

ALL 26 VENUES IN THE 2026 GAME RECORDS, RANKED BY GAMES HOSTED

VENUE	HOME TEAM	GAMES	ATTENDANCE	AVERAGE
Chase Center	Golden State	22	397,408	18,064
Barclays Center	New York	22	363,956	16,543
Gainbridge Fieldhouse	Indiana	22	361,379	16,426
Moda Center	Portland	22	318,310	14,469
Target Center	Minnesota	22	271,730	12,351
Climate Pledge Arena	Seattle	22	267,128	12,142
Mortgage Matchup Center	Phoenix	22	244,805	11,128
Crypto.com Arena	Los Angeles	21	277,963	13,236
CareFirst Arena	Washington	21	88,200	4,200
Wintrust Arena	Chicago	20	153,670	7,684
Michelob ULTRA Arena	Las Vegas	19	196,380	10,336
Mohegan Sun Arena	Connecticut	19	151,325	7,964
College Park Center	Dallas	19	118,500	6,237
Gateway Center	Atlanta	16	57,466	3,592
Coca-Cola Coliseum	Toronto	15	123,082	8,205
State Farm Arena	Atlanta	6	94,960	15,827
Scotiabank Arena	Toronto	3	53,132	17,711
T-Mobile Arena	Las Vegas	3	50,144	16,715
American Airlines Center	Dallas	3	49,977	16,659
Bell Centre	Toronto (Montreal)	2	33,720	16,860
Rogers Arena	Toronto (Vancouver)	2	28,291	14,146
United Center	Chicago	2	27,541	13,770
PeoplesBank Arena	Connecticut (Hartford)	2	25,056	12,528
TD Garden	Connecticut (Boston)	1	16,378	16,378
Capital One Arena	Washington	1	9,798	9,798
Galen Center	Los Angeles	1	6,247	6,247

Game records exclude the All-Star Game, the Commissioner's Cup final, the playoffs, and the postponed July 16 Dallas and New York game. Arena names follow the game feed and can reflect later naming rights changes. The research verifies a seating configuration only for Chase Center, so the table shows no occupancy rates.

C Appendix C: Method and data notes

C.1 Attendance reconciliation

The 330 game records for 2026 sum to 3,786,546 and match all 15 team totals. The 2024 records run 20 visits above the league's published total and the corrected 2025 records 471 below it; headline growth uses the published 2025 total of 3,142,082, and neither difference is adjusted.

C.2 Average crowd growth

The league release gives 11,474 a game in 2026, up 21%. The 2025 total of 3,142,082 across 286 games gives 10,986, so the calculated increase is 4.4%. Team changes use 2025 team averages rounded in the source dataset.

C.3 Capacity and sellouts

Reference capacities come from venue pages and change with curtaining, floor seats, and closed sections. Only Golden State's 18,064 configuration is verified, so the briefing calculates no occupancy rate or empty seat count. Sellout counts are the league's.

C.4 Revenue and valuations

Forbes revenue figures are 2025 regular season estimates rounded to $1M, excluding playoffs. Values include arena economics and exclude arena real estate. Forbes and Sportico differ in timing and method and stay separate. Team estimates are not added to league revenue, since distributions would count twice.

C.5 Revenue per home visit

Each team's 2025 revenue estimate divided by its 2025 home attendance from game records. The ratio includes media distributions, sponsorship, and merchandise and is not a ticket yield.

C.6 Ticket prices and renewals

150 price observations for six teams keep their original season, basis, and currency, with prices rebuilt per included game. The 17 same seat examples, 14 of them shown in Figure 10, and 66 community records may share observations and are not pooled. The 2026 and 2027 packages include 22 to 26 events, so each comparison divides by the events stated for that package. The report infers no league price increase.

C.7 Partner census

League partner rows are a verified selection, not a census of the 46 sponsors SBJ reported. P&G brands count as touchpoints under one agreement. A blank fee or end year means none is public.

C.8 Media and audience

National inventories come from league schedule releases and overlap through simulcasts and event windows. NBC total audience delivery, Nielsen linear figures, streaming averages, ION windows, and unique reach use different bases and are not ranked as one series.

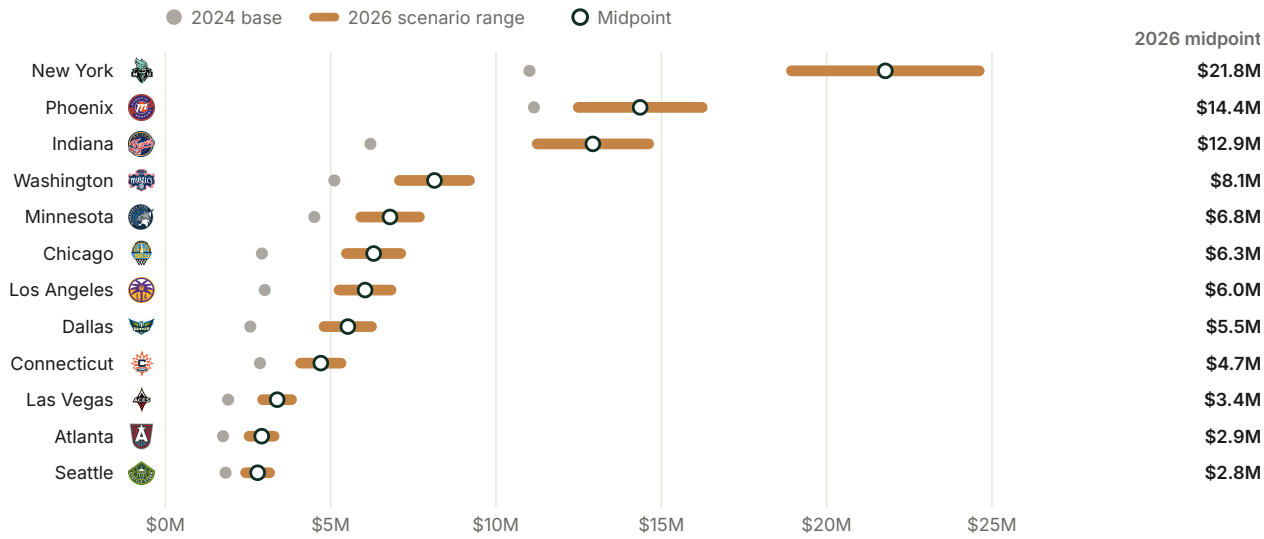
C.9 Dates of the data

Research cut off: October 25, 2026. Crowds: 2026 regular season. Team finances: 2025 estimates; values May 2026. Sponsorship scenario: 2024 base. Prices: 2025 to 2027. Jersey census: May 2026. Team membership pages: October 2026. Follower snapshot: retrieved October 25, 2026. Zoomph season measures: 2026 regular season, May 8 to September 24, numbers as of October 1, 2026. Finals status: October 25, 2026.

C.10 Illustrative sponsorship scenario

This scenario is an illustration of stated assumptions and not a projection of any team's revenue. The 2024 base is each team's estimated sponsorship from a licensed sponsorship database, built by splitting deals that cover several teams between those teams; it does not use contract fees. The 2025 step holds each team's sponsorship share of revenue constant, so sponsorship grows at the team's Forbes revenue growth from 2024 to 2025. The 2026 step adds 0% to 30%, where 30% is the only disclosed 2026 partnership growth figure, from Golden State. The report does not use the results to compare teams' commercial performance.

Figure 31. Illustrative scenario: 2026 team sponsorship under stated assumptions ILLUSTRATIVE SCENARIO



The scenario starts from each team's estimated 2024 sponsorship in a licensed database, grows it at the team's Forbes revenue growth from 2024 to 2025, and adds 0% to 30% for 2026. Total revenue growth is a loose guide to sponsorship growth, and the 30% upper figure comes from one team, Golden State, the only team to disclose its 2026 partnership growth. The ranges therefore show what the assumptions produce and are not credible bounds for any team, and the ordering does not measure which teams sell sponsorship well. The scenario leaves out Golden State, Portland, and Toronto, which have no 2024 base.

Source: Playbook Strategies analysis. 2024 team sponsorship base from a licensed sponsorship database; growth from Forbes team revenue estimates, 2024 and 2025; Golden State partnership growth from Digiday, October 2026. Appendix C.10 sets out the method.

D Appendix D: Supporting market detail

Supporting detail with different reporting periods and scopes. The values answer specific questions and do not compare directly with each other.

LOCAL AND CANADIAN DISTRIBUTION, 2026

TEAM	LOCAL OUTLET	ACCESS	GAMES
Atlanta	WANF / WPCH / Peachtree Sports Network	Free broadcast	Not standardized
Chicago	WCIU The U	Free broadcast	24
Connecticut	NBC Sports Boston	Regional pay TV	27
Dallas	KFAA	Free broadcast	24
Golden State	KPIX / KPIX+ / KMAX / KOVR	Free broadcast	26
Indiana	WTHR / WALV	Free broadcast	18
Las Vegas	FOX5 / Silver State Sports	Free broadcast	Not standardized
Los Angeles	Spectrum SportsNet	Regional pay TV	27
Minnesota	KARE 11; FOX 9+ Sept. 20	Free streaming / some broadcast	Not standardized
New York	WNYW FOX 5 / WWOR My9	Free broadcast	23
Phoenix	3TV / Arizona's Family Sports	Free broadcast	36
Portland	Rose City SportsNet / KPDX	Free broadcast	Not standardized
Seattle	KOMO ABC / KUNS CW	Free broadcast	33
Toronto	TSN; selected CTV	Canadian national package	Not standardized
Washington	MNMT	Regional pay TV / DTC	32

Source: team broadcast announcements, 2026. Counts follow each release and may include preseason games where noted in the source; national and local windows overlap.

FORBES AND SPORTICO VALUES, 2026

TEAM	FORBES 2026	SPORTICO 2026	DIFFERENCE	FORBES CHANGE
Golden State	$780M	$850M	+$70M	Not ranked in 2025
New York	$600M	$600M	$0M	+50%
Indiana	$580M	$560M	−$20M	+57%
Seattle	$430M	$425M	−$5M	+30%
Phoenix	$425M	$420M	−$5M	+42%
Las Vegas	$420M	$410M	−$10M	+35%
Los Angeles	$350M	$400M	+$50M	+49%
Dallas	$340M	$325M	−$15M	+36%
Minnesota	$320M	$355M	+$35M	+39%
Chicago	$310M	$320M	+$10M	+29%
Connecticut	$300M	$300M	$0M	+50%
Washington	$280M	$310M	+$30M	+37%
Atlanta	$250M	$280M	+$30M	+32%
Total	**$5.39B**	**$5.56B**	**+$170M**	**+41% (12 teams)**

Source: Forbes, May 7, 2026; Sportico values as reported by Sporting News, 2026.

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Last updated: October 27, 2026. Each dataset has its own collection date, listed in Appendix C.9. Playbook Strategies drew the figures from sources believed reliable on those dates and has not audited them. Accounting scope, audience measurement, and disclosure differ by source. The scenarios are illustrations, and every input needs checking before a commercial decision. This document is for information and is not financial advice. Playbook Strategies is independent of the WNBA, the WNBPA, and the teams, and none of them reviewed or endorsed this briefing.

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